

INBRIEF



Renovated butterfly park reopened at Vandalur Zoo

The renovated Butterfly Park at Arignar Anna Zoological Park (AAZP), Vandalur, has reopened with improved infrastructure, naturalistic features, and interactive facilities for visitors, an official release said. One of the zoo's popular attractions, the Butterfly Park is located near Otteri Lake and spread across 2.7 hectares. It has been designed to support the complete life cycle of butterflies, with dedicated host and nectar gardens that provide plants for breeding, feeding, and habitat enrichment. The release said that the renovation had focused on enhancing the naturalistic setting and visitor experience, while providing a suitable environment for butterflies to thrive. The park also features an indoor enclosure that allows visitors to observe butterflies at close quarters.

2 men killed during temple festival in Kancheepuram

Two men were hacked to death by a gang during a temple festival at Padunelli village in Kancheepuram district late on Sunday night. The deceased have been identified as Neelakandan, 26, and Chandru, 26, both residents of the village. The police arrested one person named R. Bhagawati and detained two others. According to the police, a quarrel broke out at the festival after a group of intoxicated men insisted that film songs be played. Though police personnel intervened and removed the men from the spot, an unidentified gang, later, attacked Chandru and Vicky with sharp weapons and fled. The incident triggered tension in the village, with relatives of the victims confronting the police and alleging that the attack occurred despite security personnel being deployed at the festival. Police officials pacified the relatives and sent the bodies for post-mortem examination.

Halt railway station at Kilambakkam to be ready by October

A Southern Railway official says the State govt. has deposited ₹20.82 cr. for the station; construction of Platform 1, booking office completed

TRACK TALES

R. Srikanth
CHENNAI

The halt railway station which is being executed by the Southern Railway in Kilambakkam, is expected to be completed by October this year. The project has been delayed and one of the main reasons was the skywalk project linking the Kilambakkam bus terminus with the station. For the skywalk project, permission for placing the girder across the railway tracks was needed for the Chennai Metropolitan Development Authority (CMDA) from the Southern Railway.

Shailendra Singh, Divisional Railway Manager of Chennai division, during a press meet held last week, said the State government had deposited ₹20.82 crore for construction of the new halt station. The construction of platform number 1 was completed, whereas civil work for platform numbers 2 and 3 was nearing completion. Construction of a temporary booking office and a toilet block was also completed, he added.

Regarding the linking of the skywalk project, which is under progress and be-



Key facility: Construction of the skywalk under way at Kilambakkam in Chennai on Monday. R. RAVINDRAN

ing executed by the CMDA, Mr. Shailendra Singh said coordination with the State authorities for launch of the skywalk girder and additional passenger amenities is being done. A meeting in this regard was held and the same has been resolved for planning of the girder launch.

The CMDA was fully given charge of the skywalk project for seamless execution. However, the project on the railway premises was delayed due to the demand made by the Southern railway for way leave charges of entering the property.

S.N. Narain, Chief Public

Relations Officer of Southern Railway, said that in the last meeting organised by officials of the Chennai division with CMDA and CUMTA, the Southern Railway had accepted in principle the request for waiving off the way leave charges.

A memorandum of understanding had to be signed by the State Government as permission to fix the girder.

A senior official of CMDA said they received the communication for waiving off of way leave charges and soon a decision regarding the MoU would be taken.

Conducted 'limited inquiry' before accepting resignations of 6 AIADMK MLAs: Speaker

Mohamed Imranullah S.
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Assembly Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar, on Monday, told the Madras High Court that he had conducted a "limited inquiry" before accepting the resignations of six AIADMK MLAs between May 26, 2026 and June 29, 2026.

In an affidavit filed before the first Division Bench comprising Chief Justice Sushrut Arvind Dharmadhikari and Justice G. Arul Murugan, he claimed to have inquired with the MLAs to ascertain whether they were resigning voluntarily, and whether their resignation letters were genuine.

The Speaker also entered appearance through Senior Counsel K.K. Venugopal in order to oppose a batch of four writ petitions filed by AIADMK Whip Agri S.S. Krishnamurthy. The petitioner had challenged the acceptance of the resignations submitted by Esaki Subaya, S. Jayakumar, Maragatham Kumaravel, P. Sathyabama, C. Vijayabaskar who had been elected from Ambasamudram, Perundurai, Maduranthagam, Dharapuram, Viralmalai, and Karur constituencies respectively.

Mr. Prabhakar filed the affidavit after senior counsel V. Giri, representing the writ petitioner, had during the last hearing contended



J.C.D. Prabhakar

the Speaker had not subjected himself to the jurisdiction of the High Court by authorising the Legislative Assembly Secretary R. Santhi to file a counter affidavit on his behalf. Asserting there was no disrespectful intent behind the filing of the counter affidavit through the Assembly Secretary, the Speaker said: "Any suggestions to the contrary by the petitioner are mischievous and stoutly denied."

As a co-constitutional authority, "I have the highest regard and respect for the judicial process of this honourable Court and hence it has never been my intent to abstain from participating in the present matter... Since I was under the bonafide impression that it would suffice if the second respondent (Assembly Secretary), who had the necessary competence to depose as regards the facts germane to the present matter, files a counter, I had not formally entered appearance through a law officer in the present matter," the Speak-

er explained.

Clarifying all six MLAs had tendered their resignations in person and in their own handwritings, the Speaker said, he had individually inquired with each of those MLAs to find out whether they were resigning out of their free will and own volition and that there was no element of undue influence or coercion behind their decisions to resign.

He also told the court there were no other materials or circumstances to doubt the genuineness or voluntary nature of their resignations.

"In these circumstances, there was no further inquiry necessary in my view... In this entire sequence of events I was guided by the mandate stipulated under the proviso to Article 190(3)(b) of the Constitution and Rule 22 of the Tamil Nadu Legislative Assembly (TNLA) Rules," the affidavit read.

Mr. Prabhakar said, the inquiry conducted by him was in consonance with the permissible scope of inquiry envisaged under the Constitution and the TNLA Rules and therefore the acceptance of the resignation letters was perfectly valid.

After taking the Speaker's affidavit on file, the Chief Justice's Bench adjourned the hearing of the case to September 1, 2026 by when the writ petitioner was asked to file his reply to the affidavit.

‘Long-term vision is to give certificates within a stipulated timeframe’

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Minister for Revenue and Disaster Management, K.A. Sengottaiyan, on Monday, said in the Assembly during Demand for Grants that his depart-

ment will implement a new practice of appointing officials in a three-tier system to speed up the process of providing certificates and that it is the long-term vision of the State government to provide all necessary certi-

ificates within a stipulated timeframe.

Making a slew of announcements, Mr Sengottaiyan said, "As a start, 12 sub taluk offices would be set up at a cost of ₹1.02 crore under a Deputy Tahsildar to dispatch essential

certificates for the public in the place where they are dwelling. 12,466 village administrative officials and 1,253 taluk revenue inspectors will be provided with tablets at a cost of ₹688.63 crore to provide services of the Revenue and Disaster

Management department."

Disaster management

A Special Job Security Act will also be enacted to protect the officials of the Revenue and Disaster Management when discharging their duties.

Made of Chennai Run on Aug. 23; last date to register is Aug. 19

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

The last date for registration for *The Hindu* Made of Chennai Run 2026, which will take place on August 23 at Besant Nagar beach, is August 19.

The registration fee for a 5K run is ₹699; for the 10K run it is ₹799.

The *Hindu* Made of Chennai Run 2026 is presented by Casagrand and co-powered by AU Small Finance Bank, in association with Union Bank of India, Joyalukkas, and Andhra Pradesh Tourism.

The event is supported by LIC, Orchids - The International School and Supermilk as Associate Partners; Hindustan Group of Insti-

tutions as Education Partner; Toyota as Mobility Partner; IndianOil as Energy Partner; AkshayaKalpa Organic as Good Food Partner; Licious as Protein Partner; StudyIn as Overseas Education Partner; Murugan Idli as Food Partner; Bisleri as Hydration Partner; and BIG FM as Radio Partner.

It is being co-hosted by Chennai Runners, in partnership with the Greater Chennai Corporation, Tamil Nadu Tourism Development Corporation (TTDC), SDAT and Run for Drugs.

To register for participation in the event, scan the QR code or visit: newsth.live/MOC2026RPA

Students injured in accident

CHENNAI: Students and the driver of a private school bus sustained minor injuries after the bus hit a container trailer near Janapanchatram junction in Tiruvallur district on Mon-

day. The police said the bus was travelling from Chennai airport to the school in Ponneri.

The injured students and the driver were taken to a private hospital.

THE HINDU
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S. E. RAILWAY - TENDER
E-NIT No. : ST-RNCT3-26-CCTVYARD-LCII. For and on behalf of President of India, Senior Divisional Signal and Telecommunication Engineer, S. E. Railway, Ranchi invites e-tender for the following works : **Name of the work:** Execution of S&T work in connection with 1) Supply, Installation, Testing and Commissioning of Yard Closed Circuit Television System at 9 stations in Ranchi Division. 2) Provision of Closed Circuit Television System at 11 nos. of LC Gates (Non-interlocked) over Ranchi Division along with comprehensive AMC for a period of 5 years. **Advertised Value:** ₹ 2,72,88,031.29. **EMD :** ₹ 5,45,800/-. **Cost of Tender Document:** ₹ 0. **Date & Time for closing of e-tender:** 07.09.2026 at 11.00 hrs. **Bidding Start Date:** 24.08.2026. **Website particulars :** www.irops.gov.in (works tender). (PR-627)

CHITTARANJAN LOCOMOTIVE WORKS
Open E-Tender
No. COS/CRJ/PUB/e-Tender/19/0162, Date: 13/08/2026. The following E-Tenders can be accessed under the link www.irops.gov.in. Offers for such e-Tender can be submitted only electronically by accessing the link www.irops.gov.in → login → E-Tender Stores/Supply. Vendors may also contact the following officials to obtain clarification regarding particular tender or IREPS related information if any, for Dy. CMM/P/CLW/Chittaranjan, 9163340721 or AMMP/P, 9163342746. Office Address: Office of The PCMM/CLW/Chittaranjan, SL No.:1011, Tender No.: 74263738. Brief Description of Item: Push/Pull Rod for WAG-9HIC to Drg. No. - 1209-01.113-006 Alt-6 and 1209-01.413-024. [01 (One) Set consisting of 02 (Two) items as per Set Details attached]. [Warranty Period: 30 Months after the date of delivery]. Quantity:409.00 set. Earnest Money Deposit (Rupees): ₹ 371420.00. Tender Closing Date & Time (IST): 25/09/2026 at 11:00 AM. PR6/462 PCMM/CLW/Chittaranjan Visit us on: www.facebook.com/clwrailways

Circle Around, Celebrate Together, Carry The Legacy Forward
AU Small Finance Bank's 'M' circle celebrates the roles, dreams and milestones that make every woman unique. A circle to support The Hindu Made of Chennai's Saree Walk, a celebration of women, wellness and the joy of being themselves.
Date : August 23, 2026
Time : 6:15 AM
Venue : Besant Nagar
Scan the QR code or visit newsth.live/MOC2026PA to register.
'M' circle - For every Me, at every Milestone Exclusive Banking Solutions for Women
Made Of Chennai SAREE WALK THE HINDU
Co-powered by M by AU SMALL FINANCE BANK
Free entry with prior registration

CORRIGENDUM NO. 01 AGAINST TENDER NOTICE NO. M-TSK-2026-30
Corrigendum no. 01 against Tender Notice No. M-TSK-2026-30, Date: 24-07-2026 has been issued.
The closing date & time of above tender has been extended upto 19-08-2026 at 13:00 hrs. For more detail kindly visit website www.irops.gov.in for details.
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PUBLIC NOTICE
NOTICE is hereby given to the public at large that we are investigating the clear & marketable title of land admeasuring an extent of approximately 12.06 Acres out of 12.49 Acres situated at Karanail Village, Tiruvallur Taluk, Tiruvallur District, Tamil Nadu ("Land") owned by M/s. Karanail Agrotech Pvt. Ltd. The details of Survey numbers, extent with patta and ownership details are set herein below:
Survey No. Total Extent/ Land as per Patta earmarked for sale (in Acre) Patta No.
108/1 0.36 0.36 489
108/3A 0.35 0.35 471
108/4A 0.35 0.35 471
108/3B 0.49 0.49 471
108/4B 0.58 0.58 471
108/3C 0.61 0.61 489
108/4C 0.49 0.49 489
108/5A 0.69 0.69 459
108/6 0.27 0.27 459
108/10A 0.25 0.25 489
108/7A 0.25 0.25 489
108/8 0.35 0.33 456
108/11A 0.37 0.37 489
108/9 0.44 0.38 456
108/12A 0.31 0.31 489
108/13A 0.33 0.33 488
109/1A1 0.55 0.41 456
109/1A2 0.54 0.43 489
109/1B1 0.31 0.21 458
111/1A 0.38 0.38 489
111/1B 0.67 0.67 489
108/2 0.25 0.25 489
111/2 1.01 1.01 489
111/4A1 1.49 1.49 543
111/4A2 0.70 0.70 489
12.49 12.06
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"Catholic Centre" 2nd Floor, No.108, Amerian Street, Chennai - 600 001. Tel: 044-25389721 / 9840170362

With four months left for deadline, only 50% of work on T3 Terminal completed

Although the overall physical progress is about 50%, nearly 80% of the mobilisation of materials has been completed, and it is possible to finish the construction by December, AAI officials say

PORT CALL
Sunitha Sekar
CHENNAI

With just four months left for the deadline, only about 50% of the T3 Terminal construction at Chennai airport has been completed so far.

Officials of Airports Authority of India (AAI) said while the contractor constructing the T3 Terminal had sought an extension of the deadline till March 2027, AAI has not agreed to it as yet.

A high-level inspection was held on Friday with a team of officials from the Ministry of Civil Aviation and AAI.

They inspected various ongoing projects within the airport. “A few members of the high-level team were not happy with the



Slow progress: While the contractor constructing the T3 Terminal had sought an extension of the deadline till March 2027, AAI has not agreed to it until now. M. SRINATH

progress of the T3 Terminal construction,” a source said.

But AAI officials said, though the overall physical progress is about 50%, nearly 80% of the mobilisation of the materials has been completed already, and hence it is possible to complete the construction by December.

“The pace is definitely bound to pick up after this.

We have not accepted the request of the contractor to extend the deadline to March. We cannot delay the project further and have to finish it in four months,” an official said.

The ₹2,467-crore phase II project included construction of an integrated terminal (combining the T2 Terminal and T3 Terminal) at Chennai airport which will serve to handle

international flight operations. The work, which commenced about seven years ago, should have been completed by 2022. Though the T2 Terminal was launched in 2023, the construction of the T4 Terminal has seen delays and the building now stares at a completion date of December 2026.

Sources said the most difficult portions of construction of the T3 Terminal have been completed already and hence, it is possible for the contractor to engage more workers and complete the work.

“One of the major reasons for the delay is, the contractor bagged the project seven years ago keeping in mind the prices of materials and labour at that point in time. But they are finding it difficult to carry on with the work with the escalating prices,” another source said.

Doctors at private hospital save woman with clots blocking blood flow to lungs

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

A 67-year-old woman who was in a potentially fatal condition after multiple blood clots obstructed blood flow to both her lungs was treated by Prashanth Hospitals, Kolathur.

According to a press release, the patient arrived with severe breathlessness, critically low oxygen levels, and low blood pressure.

The doctors, including Fazil Hussain, Consultant-Interventional Cardiologist, and Deeyaneswar D.,

Consultant-Interventional Cardiologist, and others performed an advanced catheter-based mechanical thrombectomy and removed the clots without an open surgery, improving blood flow to the lungs and heart function.

Dr. Fazil said, “When

clot-busting medication did not adequately clear the obstruction, we had to act quickly to restore blood flow. Mechanical thrombectomy allowed us to directly remove the clots and reopen the pulmonary arteries without the need for open surgery.”

In a first, State govt. to formulate policy for peri-menopausal care

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Women and child health-care were among the key priorities in the announcements made by Health Minister K.G. Arunraj on Monday. In a first, the State will formulate a “Peri-Menopausal Care Policy” to enable early identification of the physical and mental health needs of women in the peri-menopausal age group, along with screening, counselling and treatment services.

Bluetooth-enabled blood pressure (BP) monitors will be introduced to track BP in pregnant women, with real-time transmission of data to facilitate timely intervention, while children under 18 with type 1 diabetes will receive free year-round insulin supply in government hospitals at a cost of ₹9.94 crore.

In the first phase, the BP apparatus will be provided to nearly 10,000 pregnant women in 14 districts, including Kallakurichi, Nilgiris, Tirupattur, Dharmapuri, Dindigul, and Namakkal.

According to the announcement, under the peri-menopausal policy, camps would be conducted on a specific day every week at all primary health centres (PHC) and urban PHCs for symptomatic assessment, basic tests, counselling and referrals for treatment at district headquarters hospitals

and government medical college hospitals.

“Irumbu Kanmani” - School Anaemia Prevention will be rolled out at a cost of ₹6.37 crore. Haemoglobin estimation will be done for nearly 16.5 lakh adolescents studying in classes VI, IX and XI in government and government-aided schools and appropriate treatment and monitoring will be done.

The department will launch rare genetic disease screening for newborns. Nearly 4.5 lakh babies delivered in all government hospitals in the State will be screened for seven rare genetic diseases in a hub-and-spoke model. This will include congenital hypothyroidism, congenital adrenal hyperplasia, galactosemia, and biotinidase deficiency.

Neo Genesis Unit for extreme low birth weight babies will be set up at a cost of ₹16.81 crore. The intrauterine/womb-like environments will be set up at the Institute of Obstetrics and Gynaecology in Chennai and government medical college hospitals in Madurai, Coimbatore, Tirunelveli, Chengalpattu, and Tiruchir. An Autism Early Detection Programme will be launched to screen children for autism spectrum disorder. For this, 12,456 village health nurses and 5,000 doctors will be trained. A Childhood Obesity Prevention Programme will be launched in schools.

‘Chennai deserves to be celebrated for its inclusiveness’

I’ve been in Chennai for 52 years. I was 20 when I came to Chennai, practically a child. I was first called “*thangachi*”, then it became “*akka*”, then “*amma*”, and now people call me “*paati*”. Having grown up in a naturalist family, I knew that was I wanted to do. When I came here, it felt as though the world here had just been created for my arrival and enjoyment.

I never wanted to go back to Bombay (now Mumbai) despite many opportunities. Every time I travelled to another city, I would long to get back because, somehow, I never felt threatened here. When I first came, the roads were wide and open, there were very few cars, and there were many huge trees. Some parts of the city are still extremely pleasant.

Chennai deserves to be



Zai Whitaker, author and managing trustee, Madras Crocodile Bank Trust.

celebrated for its inclusiveness, the way people accept you into the community. When we started working with Irulars, so many people came forward to help. Another reason is the way people come together for the protection of natural resources. It’s wonderful that there are so many people who are still so curious when they come to the Madras Crocodile Bank Trust, right from tiny tots to older people.

(As told to Geetha Sri-mathi)

Timings

CHENNAI

TUESDAY, AUG. 18
☀️ RISE 05:57 SET 18:29
🌙 RISE 10:39 SET 22:25

WEDNESDAY, AUG. 19
☀️ RISE 05:58 SET 18:28
🌙 RISE 11:31 SET 23:08

THURSDAY, AUG. 20
☀️ RISE 05:58 SET 18:28
🌙 RISE 12:23 SET 23:54

Chennai Weather	max	min
Tiruvallur	38	26
Chennai Airport	38	28
Chennai City	37	28

Chennai Airport Today
36°C The weather will be very warm and uneasy. Night will also be comfortable. Chances of light rain and thundershowers.

Chennai Airport Tomorrow
35°C Morning will be comfortable. Day will be warm. Night will also be comfortable. Spell of light rain and thundershowers may occur.

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INBRIEF



Minister inaugurates work to desilt, restore waterbodies

The work to widen the inlet channel of Puthur Lake at Nedunkundram village panchayat in Chengalpattu district was inaugurated on Monday by Rural Development and Water Resources Minister N. Anand. The work was taken up by the Department of Rural Development and Panchayat Raj under the Viksit Bharat Guarantee for Rozgar and Ajeevika Mission (VB-G RAM G). A press release said steps are being taken to desilt and restore nearly 10,185 watercourses and irrigation canals and adjoining 809 lakes and ponds in rural areas, at a cost of ₹500 crore, before Northeast monsoon.

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Notice Inviting Tenders

TENDER No. - 01-AT-052022-C4-UG01-SC_ARC-LH

Cemindia Projects Limited invites sealed tenders from reputed, experienced, financially sound, competent and eligible agencies meeting the prescribed Eligibility and Qualification Criteria for execution of the following Architectural/Finishing Works (Provisional Sum) under CMRL-C4-UG01 Package, Chennai, Tamil Nadu through National Competitive Bidding (NCB) under the Single Stage Two Envelope System (Technical Bid and Financial Bid) for **Lighthouse Underground Station**.

Bid Document Available from: 18/08/2026 at 11.00 Hrs.
Pre-Bid Meeting Date: 28/08/2026 at 15.00 Hrs.
Bid Submission End Date: 08/09/2026 at 15.00 Hrs.
Bid Opening Date: 08/09/2026 at 15.30 Hrs.

For Tender documents, please visit our website: www.cemindia.co.in or contact Cemindia Projects Office at Chennai Lighthouse, Chennai - 600005.

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CINEMA ♦ ARTS ♦ EVENTS

MUSIC DANCE DRAMA

Naada Inbam, 24992672.
Dr. Sumithra Vasudev, Dr. Hemalatha, M. Balachandran. A splendorous neraval concert dedicated to Smt. Usharani & Sri Soundara Rajan. Today 6.15 pm at Ragasudha Hall.

Narada Gana Sabha Trust
Phone: 24993201
Today Main Hall (Sathguru Gnanananda Hall) Concluding Day of Pancha Bhootha Bharatham. Theme - "Akasa - Sky" 6.15 pm Talk by Dr. Sudha Seshayyan. 6.30 pm Dancer - Harine Jeevitha, Musician - Dr. Gayathri Girish. All are welcome.

Bharatiya Vidya Bhavan, East Mada Street, Mylapore, Chennai-4
is celebrating "**BhavaNonam**" between 17- 21 August 2026
Today: 18th August: High Tea at 6.00 pm, 6.30 pm: "**Kerala Musical Ensemble**" by Sudeep Palanad & Team. On 20th August : 6.30 pm: "**Malayalam Short Plays**" by Chennai Nataka Vedhi, Makthoob Theatre & Mythri Kalavedi. On 21st August : 6.30 pm: "**Avani**" - A Cultural Odyssey by Yogashema Sabha . All are Welcome.

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Tamil Nadu

From Page One

Chief Minister announces total waiver of crop loans of up to ₹75,000

Those who had taken loans exceeding ₹1 lakh would be given a maximum waiver of ₹35,000.

The Chief Minister said ₹5,267 crore (of the total waiver amount of ₹5,932.23 crore) had been credited into the accounts of 13.34 lakh farmers (out of 14.44 lakh farmers).

“As a result, there will be an opportunity to receive an additional waiver of up to ₹40,000, over and above the waiver amount already received. This additional crop loan waiver will impose an financial burden of approximately ₹953.06 crore on the government. Nevertheless, considering that our welfare lies in the welfare of the farmers of Tamil Nadu, this government is providing a total crop loan waiver of ₹6,220 crore to approximately 13.34 lakh farmers,” he said.

INBRIEF



Vijay apologises to DMK MLAs for Forest Minister’s remarks

Before Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay began making his announcements in the Assembly on Monday, he expressed regret to the DMK members over certain remarks made by Forest Minister R.V. Ranjithkumar. “Mentioning your leader’s name (late M. Karunanidhi) and speaking like that was wrong. On his behalf, I am saying sorry,” he said. Earlier, Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar expunged the Minister’s remarks.



TVK MLA booked for assault on journalist in Sholinghur

The Sholinghur police have registered a case against TVK MLA Kapil following allegations that he assaulted a journalist, snatched his mobile phone, deleted video recordings, and issued death threats during an altercation at the Vanniyar Community Hall at Sholinghur in Ranipet district recently. The case was registered based on the statement of T. Aranganathan, 50, a journalist from Sholinghur, who had been undergoing treatment after the alleged attack. The police booked the case under Sections 296(b), 115(2) and 351(2) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita against the MLA of Sholinghur Assembly constituency and several of his associates.

Group clash led to murder of student in Coimbatore, not drug use, says Law Minister

He appeals to the Opposition not to link drugs with the case, as it would distort the facts. Ministers meet parents of Amuthan and offer ₹6 lakh in compensation and a government job to his brother

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Law Minister R. Nirmalkumar on Monday told the Assembly that a group clash among students of an engineering college in Coimbatore led to the killing of third-year student Amuthan and drug use, as alleged by the Opposition, had no role in the killing.

Replying to a special calling attention motion moved by Leader of the Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin and others, the Minister also denied the allegation that Amuthan was killed because he had complained to the police about drug use, and the police had leaked the complaint to drug-peddlers. But the DMK members, who entered into an argument with Mr. Nirmalkumar and subsequently with Public Works Department Minister Aadhav Arjuna, staged a walkout, saying they were not satisfied with the Minister’s reply.

Mr. Nirmalkumar said the problem started when fourth-year students attacked Amuthan and his second-year friends on August 9. Amuthan’s friends retaliated the next day around 5 a.m. at their rooms at Othakkalmandapam and Poonga Nagar. Around 8.30 a.m. on the same day, Amuthan and his friends were attacked



Show of dissent: Leader of the Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin and DMK MLAs staging a walkout from the Assembly in Chennai on Monday. S.R. RAGHUNATHAN

by the other group. They took Amuthan to a ground, continued to attack him, and left him in his friend’s room around 10.30 a.m. As he remained unconscious until 3 p.m., he was taken to hospital, where doctors declared him dead.

The Minister said two cases were filed and provisions of the Scheduled Castes and the Scheduled Tribes (Prevention of Atrocities) Act were subsequently invoked (as Amuthan belonged to the Scheduled Caste). He said 15 persons had been arrested in connection with one case and two persons in the other. Mr. Nirmalkumar said the government was closely monitoring the situation. He appealed to the Opposition not to link drugs with the case, as it would distort the facts.

Social Justice Minister Vanni Arasu and Backward Classes Minister V. Sampath Kumar met Amuth-

an’s parents and offered them ₹6 lakh in compensation and a government job to his brother.

Mr. Arjuna said there was a clear link between drug culture and sexual assault on children and reiterated that there was a 40% increase in the cases filed under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012, between 2023 and 2026 when the DMK was in power.

He said drug culture did not emerge in the last 100 days; the foundation for it was laid during the DMK government. “That is why people removed you [the DMK] from power. Your defeat has direct links with drug culture,” he said.

Responding to Mr. Udhayanidhi, who raised the issue of suspected drug use by Minister for Human Resources Management D. Sarathkumar, Mr. Arjuna said there had been no

drug culture in Tamil Nadu until 2020.

Mr. Udhayanidhi on Monday rejected the allegation that the previous DMK government had failed to take steps during its five-year tenure to prevent the spread of drug culture in the State. He said the then Chief Minister M.K. Stalin had integrated the Narcotics Intelligence Bureau and the Prohibition Enforcement Department and created the Enforcement Bureau-CID (EB-CID) to achieve a drug-free State.

“Our government created awareness against drug use and seized narcotics. If data is required, it is available with the Minister,” he said while participating in a special calling-attention motion in the Assembly on the killing of Amudhan in Coimbatore and a school student Dhanush in Tiruvottiyur.

Mr. Udhayanidhi said even Chennai Police Commissioner A. Amal Raj could provide the details, as he had headed the EB-CID. “If our government had not taken measures to control drugs in the State, why did the new government give such an important position to the officer? The 15 policemen who were given awards for controlling drugs on Independence Day had worked effectively during the DMK regime,” he said.

Minister faces flak for allegedly mimicking action made before snorting of drugs

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Weeks after an old video clip surfaced showing D. Sarathkumar, now Minister for Human Resources Management, indulging in an act resembling preparation for snorting drugs, the issue figured in the Assembly on Monday.

The Minister, however, said he had already given his explanation (that he was powdering a tablet for his child on a mobile phone screen using a bank card). He wondered whether “drugs were sold at the gates of the [Chepauk] stadium”, as the alleged incident occurred during an IPL match when the DMK was in power.

“The Opposition may have differences of opinion and contrary views on what I have said. Can they raise the issue without any evidence? There is no need to raise the issue unnecessarily after I have clarified. Even in my department, there was a government job scam involving ₹888 crore,” he said.

Mr. Sarathkumar gave his explanation after Leader of the Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin accused the Minister of “crushing powder” at an IPL match. Mr. Udhayanidhi raised the issue after Law Minister R. Nirmalkumar recalled the arrest of Jaffer Sadiq, an international drug-peddler, who was allegedly seen in a photograph with former Chief Minister M.K. Stalin, his family members, and

Ministers. “Though he was arrested and cases were filed in Delhi, no case was filed in Tamil Nadu,” he alleged.

Mr. Udhayanidhi said that when the issue was brought to the notice of the DMK leadership, Sadiq was arrested and sacked from the party. “But what action did you take against the Minister? Did the police inquire into it? A lot of the ruling party workers are involved in drug-use cases,” he alleged. Former DMK Minister K.N. Nehru asked whether it was proper to raise the issue of a job scam case registered by the Directorate of Enforcement when the matter was pending in court. “We are only asking whether the Minister had used his card to crush the tablets,” he said.

AIADMK member S.P. Velumani said the complaint of the parents of Coimbatore student Amuthan was that drug use was prevalent in schools and colleges across the State. “Drug use is involved in the case. The [Law] Minister’s explanation is based on the police report, but the police had not given a proper report. Take appropriate action,” he said. Earlier, CPI(M) MLA A. Chellasamy said the “weeds” in the police force should be removed to make it efficient. AIADMK MLA R. Kamaraj said ₹6 lakh in compensation for Amuthan’s family was not adequate and sought ₹25 lakh.

‘MLAs can decide whether to stand up when CM arrives’

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Assembly Speaker J.C.D. Prabhakar said on Monday that it was up to the MLAs to decide whether or not to stand up when the Chief Minister arrived in the House.

He said, “When the Assembly convenes, there is no doubt that the Speaker, who is the presiding officer, alone gets the respect. When the Chief Minister arrives before the Assembly convenes and greets the members, I have seen

former Chief Minister Edappadi K. Palaniswami also getting up and greeting him... It is not compulsory to stand up whenever the Chief Minister or the Leader of the Opposition arrives. However, showing respect is part of Tamil culture and tradition. The individual members should decide for themselves whether or not to follow it. I am not going to compel anyone to do it.”

The curious debate on the “respect” for the Chief Minister was triggered after Minister for Hindu Reli-



J.C.D. Prabhakar

gious and Charitable Endowments Department S. Ramesh said Leader of the Opposition Udhayanidhi Stalin should be taught “dignity” as he did not stand up whenever Chief

Minister C. Joseph Vijay, “who is the representative of eight crore Tamil people”, arrived in the House.

However, DMK MLA and former Chief Minister O. Panneerselvam pointed out that the historic Assembly has a few traditions. The Speaker is its presiding officer. When the Speaker arrives, it is a long tradition for all MLAs, irrespective of their party affiliation, to stand up and offer respect. It has been the tradition for the Chief Ministers to make the gesture of ‘Vanakkam’ to the

members of the House and then take their seat.

“But going here and there to greet the members seems to be a new practice. Only the Speaker should decide whether or not to depart from the tradition of getting up only when the Speaker arrives and extend the same courtesy to the Chief Minister... He should also clarify whether the same courtesy should be shown to the Leader of the Opposition and the ruling party MLAs should stand up to offer him respect,” he said.

CM launches ‘presence-less registration’ of housing plots, apartments

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay on Monday launched compulsory ‘presence-less registration’ for the first-time registration of housing plots and apartments in multi-storey residential buildings.

A government press release said the government had already introduced ‘anywhere registration’, allowing the people to register their properties and documents without visiting the registrar’s office.

‘Presence-less registration’, the government said, was aimed at improving efficiency and transparency in registration without the people visiting the registrar’s office.

Under the procedure, those who want to register should create a login ID and submit their documents online. The seller, buyer, and witnesses should upload their Aadhaar cards, which will be verified.

The registrars should register the property documents submitted online within 24 hours or send them for correction or reject them. Certified copies can be collected after 60 days.

One of the important safeguards of ‘presence-less registration’ is the colour of the endorsement, which will be in Dynamic Random Five Colours and will change every time. The original colour digital copy will be available for 60 days in the beneficiary’s login, helping them identify the colour of their registration documents.

T.N. govt. to launch health insurance for the elderly

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu will launch the ‘Chief Minister’s Elderly Health Insurance Scheme’, covering nearly 38 lakh senior citizens aged 70 and above. The scheme will provide free medical treatment, including cancer care packages, advanced cardiac surgeries, organ transplants, and high-end diagnostic services, at empanelled government and private hospitals, with no ceiling on income, Health Minister K.G. Arunraj announced in the Assembly on Monday.

The Minister made 115 announcements for the Health Department at a total estimated outlay of ₹2,997 crore. It covered areas including policy reforms, universal free health services, new posts creation, infrastructure projects, equipment and procurement, direct beneficiary programmes and digital health initiatives.

The 87-year-old Tamil Nadu Public Health Act, 1939, will be replaced with

Major initiatives

Health Minister K.G. Arunraj made 115 announcements for his department at a total estimated outlay of ₹2,997 crore

HIGHLIGHTS

■ A ‘Master Plan for Health Infrastructure’ will be prepared in a phased manner at an estimated cost of ₹10 crore to develop modern health infrastructure across all government medical college hospitals and district headquarters hospitals

■ A care coordination scheme will be rolled out

■ The AI-powered WhatsApp chatbot for booking medical appointments will be expanded to all government hospitals; AI-technology and QR-based patient feedback will be introduced

■ AYUSH fertility treatment centres will be established at ₹1.03 crore

■ Level-1 assisted reproductive centre will be established in 31 government medical college hospitals and six district headquarters hospitals at a cost of ₹14 crore

■ A unique patient identification system will be developed to assign a single digital health ID to every patient across all government health facilities

■ Neurosurgery hubs will be established

■ Heat stroke management units to be set up in 20 district headquarters hospitals

■ New geriatric medical units in four government hospitals and palliative care centres in two hospitals for senior citizens

■ Basic life support training for the public



a modern, comprehensive Act to address contemporary and future health challenges. Dr. Arunraj said a new provision would make unsupervised home births

outside hospitals a punishable offence. Noting that Tamil Nadu was known as the country’s health capital, he said that ‘TN Medcity’, a world class integrat-

ed medical hub comprising clinical services, research, medical tourism, and AYUSH, would be established. The government will allocate ₹10 crore for the preparation of a Detailed Project Report in the first phase.

‘Nalam 360-Annual Free Health Check-up for All’ scheme will be rolled out. Under this, everyone aged 30 and above will receive 14 basic tests annually, free of cost, across 1,257 government health facilities in the State.

This will include blood pressure, ECG, haemoglobin, complete haemogram, random blood sugar, urea, creatinine, total cholesterol, serum bilirubin, urine albumin, and VIA screening. For the first time in the State, the Health Department will introduce Home Based Diagnostic Services – sample collection and testing services – in metropolitan areas on a public-private partnership model, he said. The department will come up with a ‘Positive Health Policy’ to promote

holistic health and wellbeing at the community, family, and individual levels.

2,500 staff nurse posts

Addressing a long-standing demand, Dr. Arunraj said 2,500 permanent posts of staff nurses would be created. Existing contract nurses on consolidated pay will be absorbed into regular time-scale pay. A total of 1,695 nursing posts on consolidated pay will be created at a cost of ₹42.72 crore.

A total of 3,594 medical staff across 24 categories, including pharmacists, nursing assistants, village health nurses, and ophthalmic assistants, will be recruited through the Medical Services Recruitment Board. Additionally, the department will create 284 temporary super speciality posts across 25 specialities on time-scale pay to take advanced medical care to the district-level. These posts will be created to accommodate doctors who complete their post-graduation every year and are posted in government hospitals on bond conditions.

Singing Tamil Thai Vazhthu third is not an insult: Vice-President

The Hindu Bureau
TIRUVARUR

Vice-President C.P. Radhakrishnan on Monday said singing Tamil Thai Vazhthu after Vande Mataram and Jana Gana Mana cannot be construed as an insult to the State song.

Addressing the graduands at the IIth Convocation of Central University of Tamil Nadu at Neelakudi near Tiruvarur on Monday, he called upon them to keep the nation first in their every action. “But, unfortunately, everything is being politicised in Tamil Nadu. They ask why Tamil Thai Vazhthu is not sung first. They say it is an insult. Can you insult the national song?” he asked.

“Who said it is an insult if it (Tamil Thai Vazhthu) is sung third? Can anybody insult their mother? When you cannot insult your mother and cannot insult your mother tongue, you



We should not politicise everything. When it has to be followed uniformly all over the country, we have to follow it

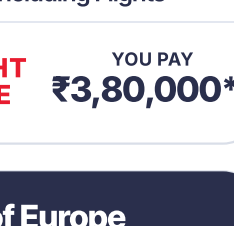
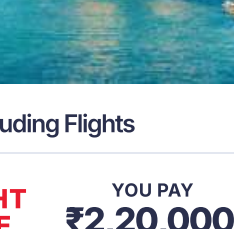
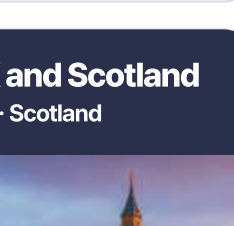
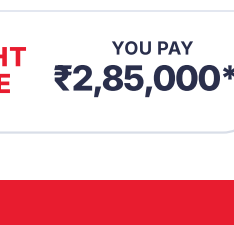
C.P. RADHAKRISHNAN
Vice-President

cannot insult your motherland either. We should not politicise everything. When it has to be followed uniformly all over the country, we have to follow it.”

Mr. Radhakrishnan observed that Vande Mataram was the one word that made the nation a free country. In Tamil Nadu too, V.O. Chidambaram Pillai and Subramaniya Siva walked village-to-village with a single slogan ‘Vande Mataram’ to urge the people to fight against the British, he added.

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Murmu gives assent to Bill to rename Kerala as Keralam

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

President Droupadi Murmu has given assent to a Bill to rename Kerala as Keralam, with the legislation now becoming a law.

The Lok Sabha had passed the Kerala (Alteration of Name) Bill, 2026, on August 11, followed by the Rajya Sabha the next day.

In the Rajya Sabha, Minister of State for Home Affairs Nityanand Rai said the State Assembly passed a resolution in 2024, urging the Centre to bring a law to change the name of the State to Keralam.

“The Bill provides that the State of Kerala will be known as the State of Keralam, and hence there is a proposal to rename the State of Kerala to Keralam,” he said.

The Kerala government had forwarded a resolution passed by the State Assembly regarding the name change to the Centre in June 2024. Subsequently, President Murmu referred the Bill to the State legislature for its views, following which the Assembly adopted a unanimous resolution.

The Kerala (Alteration of Name) Bill provides for the alteration of the State’s name and contains necessary amendments to the Constitution and consequential provisions. Amendments will be made in the First Schedule by modifying the name of Kerala as Keralam in accordance with Article 3.

SC decides to watch progress on Cauvery water sharing

Karnataka says it released over 12,000 cusecs by 8 a.m. on August 17 as ordered by CWMA despite distress conditions; T.N. had sought 37 tmc ft from August 12 to 31; top court posts case to Aug. 24

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Supreme Court on Monday decided to wait and watch the progress in Cauvery water sharing between Karnataka and Tamil Nadu, even as Karnataka said that over 12,000 cusecs (one tmc ft) was released by 8 a.m. on August 17.

A Bench headed by Justice Vikram Nath addressed Tamil Nadu, saying “it is not that the State [Karnataka] is not giving water to you”.

The Cauvery Water Management Authority (CWMA) had earlier directed Karnataka to ensure the release of 12,000 cusecs a day from August 12 for the



Water being released from the Kabini Dam in Mysuru district of Karnataka on August 3 after it neared its full storage capacity. PTI

next 15 days to Tamil Nadu.

Tamil Nadu, represented by senior advocate C.S. Vaidyanthan, said the court must ensure that Karnataka strictly followed the CWMA order. The court said it would watch the progress while seeking a fresh status report. It posted the case to August 24.

Senior advocates Shyam Divan and Mohan V. Kataraki, for Karnataka, submitted it was “erroneous” to allege that it had not complied with the CWMA fiat. “We have complied in full, especially considering the fact that this is a distress year,” Mr. Divan submitted.

The Karnataka affidavit

said it was able to overcome the challenges of a distress year and worsening El Nino conditions to ensure the supply of water from its Kabini reservoir due to large inflows owing to good rainfall in the Wayanad area above the Kabini catchment. “The releases from the KRS and Kabini reservoirs have already been reflected at the inter-State border at Bili-gundlu. From July 29 to August 10, Karnataka has released 1,64,080 cusecs from its reservoirs,” it said.

Tamil Nadu had urged the court to direct Karnataka to release the balance quantity of 21.357 tmc ft due as on August 12. It had also sought the release of 37 tmc ft of Cauvery water from August 12 to 31.

SIT investigation finds irregularities in A.P. Group-I recruitment process

The Hindu Bureau
VIJAYAWADA

The Special Investigation Team (SIT) probing the Andhra Pradesh Public Service Commission (APPSC) Group-I recruitment process, for which the notification was issued on December 31, 2018, reportedly found many irregularities in evaluation of answer sheets and selection of candidates.

As many as 1.14 lakh candidates had applied for the recruitment exam. The prelims were held in May 2019 and the mains in December 2020.

Subsequently, evaluation was conducted and 9,679 aspirants qualified for mains and 165 were finally selected. During investigation, it was found that the evaluation process had been entrusted to two private firms, which were

reportedly known to the then APPSC Secretary P.S.R. Anjaneyulu.

The SIT found that 452 qualified subject experts identified by the APPSC were sidelined and about 25 school teachers, private lecturers, 66 data entry operators, clerks, security guards and electricians had been engaged for evaluation. It was found that answer sheets were shifted from the APPSC strong

room and allegedly kept in a resort for about 84 days violating the APPSC Rules.

Out of the 165 selected candidates, OMR sheets of 160 candidates were reportedly altered, and differences in signatures were detected in case of 89 candidates, the SIT, which submitted its report recently, stated.

Further probe is under way, the investigation officers said in the report.

Centre should reconsider Mines Bill, Satheesan urges Modi

The Hindu Bureau
THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

Chief Minister of Kerala V.D. Satheesan has written to Prime Minister Narendra Modi urging a relook at the provisions of the Mines and Minerals (Development and Regulation) Amendment Bill, 2026, that “restrict the taxation powers of States over mineral rights and mineral-bearing lands.”

The amendments, the Chief Minister, wrote, have far-reaching implications for the constitutional and fiscal powers of States, particularly their authority to levy taxes and other imposts on mineral rights and mineral-bearing lands.

“The amendments will have particular implications for Kerala. The State possesses significant mineral-bearing areas... Restricting the State’s fiscal authority over mineral-bearing lands could adversely affect State revenues,” he said.

Section 9D of the Bill, recently passed by Parliament, restricts the ability of States to impose any tax, cess or other levy on mineral rights and mineral-bearing lands, except within parameters prescribed by the Centre. The amendments also seek to bring mineral-bearing lands within the ambit of Union government regulation and invalidate certain past State levies. “These provisions raise serious concerns on the federal distribution of powers,” he said.

WEATHERWATCH

Rainfall, temperature & air quality in select metros yesterday

TEMPERATURE DATA: IMD, POLLUTION DATA: CPCB, MAP: INSAT/IMD (TAKEN AT 20.15 HRS)

Forecast for Tuesday: Heavy/very heavy rainfall likely at isolated places over Jammu & Kashmir, Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh, Punjab, Delhi, Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Assam, Meghalaya, Manipur, Tripura, Sikkim, West Bengal, Jharkhand, Odisha, Chhattisgarh, Madhya Pradesh, Tamil Nadu, Puducherry, Karaikal, Keralam and Mahe

CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN	CITY	RAIN	MAX	MIN
Agartala	0.6.....	31.5.....	26.0	Kurnool		35.0.....	25.6
Ahmedabad	2.5.....	32.0.....	25.4	Lucknow	9.....	27.3.....	24.0
Aizawl	1.....	30.7.....	22.5	Madurai		39.0.....	26.5
Bengaluru		28.9.....	21.0	Mangaluru	18.6.....	28.7.....	23.4
Bhopal	1.1.....	26.8.....	23.0	Mumbai	5.8.....	29.4.....	25.1
Bhubaneswar	15.5.....	29.8.....	25.1	Mysuru		30.2.....	19.8
Chandigarh	1.5.....	34.6.....	24.0	New Delhi		35.8.....	27.8
Chennai		37.6.....	28.1	Patna		33.4.....	28.4
Coimbatore		32.8.....	22.4	Port Blair	6.3.....	29.6.....	25.6
Dehradun	6.8.....	31.9.....	23.2	Prayagraj	73.4.....	28.5.....	25.5
Gangtok	2.6.....	22.2.....	19.0	Puducherry		36.8.....	28.0
Goa	4.2.....	32.0.....	25.2	Pune		27.6.....	23.2
Guwahati	1.8.....	33.6.....	25.8	Raipur	58.....	26.6.....	23.5
Hubballi		28.0.....	22.0	Ranchi		30.4.....	23.0
Hyderabad	0.6.....	32.2.....	23.8	Shillong	9.5.....	22.4.....	19.7
Imphal		29.2.....	21.9	Shimla		27.4.....	20.0
Jaipur		32.8.....	26.5	Srinagar		33.0.....	20.0
Kochi	0.2.....	31.0.....	25.8	Thiruvananthapuram	4.5.....	32.0.....	23.8
Kohima		24.0.....	20.0	Tiruchirappalli		39.7.....	28.0
Kolkata	14.....	28.3.....	25.8	Vijayawada	6.....	35.6.....	26.4
Kozhikode	14.4.....	32.6.....	24.5	Visakhapatnam		32.3.....	28.6

(Rainfall data in mm; temperature in Celsius)

Pollutants in the air you are breathing

CITIES	SO ₂	NO ₂	CO	PM _{2.5}	PM ₁₀	CODE	Yesterday
Ahmedabad	31.....	38.....	70.....	47.....	66.....		In observation made at 4.00 p.m., Leh, Ladakh, recorded an overall air quality index (AQI) score of 185 indicating a moderate level of pollution. In contrast, Aizawl, Mizoram recorded a healthy AQI score of 14
Bengaluru	12.....	35.....	55.....	57.....	73.....		
Chennai	5.....	7.....	31.....	30.....	190.....		
Delhi	18.....	37.....	107.....	175.....	287.....		
Hyderabad	9.....	13.....	36.....	39.....	54.....		
Kolkata	13.....	23.....	41.....	69.....	82.....		
Lucknow	6.....	20.....	63.....	30.....	35.....		
Mumbai	7.....	12.....	34.....	35.....	77.....		
Pune		12.....	94.....	45.....	56.....		
Visakhapatnam	26.....	81.....	15.....	49.....	116.....		

Air Quality Code: ■ Poor ■ Moderate ■ Good (Readings indicate average AQI)

SO₂: Sulphur Dioxide. Short-term exposure can harm the respiratory system, making breathing difficult. It can affect visibility by reacting with other air particles to form haze and stain culturally important objects such as statues and monuments.

NO₂: Nitrogen Dioxide. Aggravates respiratory illness, causes haze to form by reacting with other air particles, causes acid rain, pollutes coastal waters.

CO: Carbon monoxide. High concentration in air reduces oxygen supply to critical organs like the heart and brain. At very high levels, it can cause dizziness, confusion, unconsciousness and even death.

PM_{2.5} & PM₁₀: Particulate matter pollution can cause irritation of the eyes, nose and throat, coughing, chest tightness and shortness of breath, reduced lung function, irregular heartbeat, asthma attacks, heart attacks and premature death in people with heart or lung disease

VCK should grow into a force capable of ruling Tamil Nadu, says Thirumavalavan

The Hindu Bureau
KALLAKURICHI

Viduthalai Chiruthaigal Katchi (VCK) president Thol. Thirumavalavan on Monday said the VCK, now an Election Commission of India-recognised political party, should grow into a force capable of ruling Tamil Nadu.

“Until now, the VCK has been part of alliances led by parties such as the DMK, the AIADMK and the Congress. We are now allied with my dear brother [Chief Minister] C. Joseph Vijay, president of the Tamilaga Vetti Kazhagam (TVK). The VCK and the TVK will now travel together, and the VCK will emerge as a ruling party,” Mr. Thirumavalavan said while addressing the “Tamil nationalist” public rally at Ulundurpet in Kallakurichi district.

The VCK has emerged as a political force that cannot be ignored in Tamil Nadu, Mr. Thirumavalavan said.

A total of 125 resolutions were passed at the conference.

Tamil Eelam

The creation of a separate and independent Tamil Eelam has been the consistent stand of the VCK. The party urged the Sri Lankan government to conduct a referendum among Tamils to decide on the demand for a separate Tamil Eelam.

One of the resolutions demanded genuine State autonomy for Tamil Nadu in order to protect the Tamil people’s linguistic, ethnic, cultural, econom-

The VCK has emerged as a political force that cannot be ignored in Tamil Nadu

THOL. THIRUMAVALAVAN
VCK leader

ic, and political rights.

The conference also called for constitutional amendments to expand the State’s powers in education, economy, administration, arts, literature, and culture.

The conference also rejected the “hegemonic politics of one nation, one religion, one culture, one government, one rule, one party.”

Enhanced State rights

The conference also passed resolutions demanding greater financial autonomy for Tamil Nadu and other States, enhanced State rights, ensuring social justice and equal rights while advancing Tamil nationalism, and protection of Tamil language, among others.

Minister for Social Justice Vanni Arasu, Villupuram Member of Parliament D. Ravikumar, and former MLA M. Sinthanaiselvan participated in the conference.

T.N. govt. to file plea against order to evict people from Megamalai

The Hindu Bureau
CHENNAI

Tamil Nadu Law Minister R Nirmalkumar on Monday said the State government, as per the direction of Chief Minister C. Joseph Vijay, had taken steps to file a review petition in the Supreme Court against its order directing the eviction of people and farmers from the Megamalai region in Theni district. “We have filed a petition today. The case is likely to come up for hearing on Wednesday,” he said while replying to a special calling-attention motion in the Assembly.

He charged the failure of the DMK and AIADMK governments to handle the issue properly had resulted in the present situation.

“It was in 2009, when the DMK was in power, that it was declared a Reserve Forest. It was declared the Srivilliputhur-Megamalai Tiger Reserve in February 2021, when the AIADMK was in power. If the governments had handled the issue properly and exempted deserving people, we would not have faced the present situation,” he added.

The Minister said a Central team had toured the State for eight months between July 2025 and February 2026, conducted a study in Tamil Nadu and, based on the documents submitted by the committee, the Supreme Court delivered its order on eviction. “If the government had provided adequate documents and evidence to the team, the people could have been exempted,” he said.

KARNATAKA INDUSTRIAL AREAS DEVELOPMENT BOARD
(A Government of Karnataka Undertaking)
No.2, 2/1 & 2/3, Kalidasa Marg, 1st Main Road, Gandhinagar,
Bengaluru - 560009. Phone No. 080-22265383 website:www.kiadb.in

No.IADB/ENGG/ETND-EP-32/2735/2026-27

Date:17.08.2026

SHORT TERM NOTICE INVITING TENDER
(Through GOK Karnataka Public Procurement Portal Only)

Item Rate Tender under two cover bid system is invited for the works mentioned below as per the Karnataka Transparency in Public Procurement Act 1999 and Rules 2000 through electronic procurement from eligible Contractors who have got adequate financial resources, state of the art technology, suitable construction equipments, technical man power & sufficient past experience for the following works as per the schedule given below:

Name of the works: (1) Providing and laying of Effluent Network at Harohalli Industrial Area 5th Phase, Ramanagar Taluk, Bengaluru South District. (2) Providing and laying of Domestic Sewer Network at Harohalli Industrial Area 5th Phase, Ramanagar Taluk, Bengaluru South District.

● Last Date and Time for Receipt of Tenders: **05.09.2026** upto **4:00 pm**.

Applicants May download bidding documents from the Karnataka Public Procurement portal <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>

Sd/-
Engineer-In-Chief

DIPRI/CP/2203/CCL/2026-27

CASAGRANT
building aspirations

Presents

Made Of Chennai TRIVIA QUIZ

THE HINDU GROUP

Co-powered by

- Inaugurated in 1941 near Mount Road, the iconic Casino Theatre stands as a definitive monument to which global design movement?
- Which musical genre, born on the streets of North Chennai and originally associated with funeral performances, has since found a major place in Tamil cinema and popular culture?
- Which renowned production designer created the elaborate Dharavi sets at Venus Studio in Madras for Mani Ratnam's 1987 classic Nayakan?

Scan the QR or visit newsth.live/MOC2026PA to take the quiz. Top 3 winners* every day win gift vouchers.

Answer to yesterday's quiz:

- Sri Parthasarathy Swami Sabha
- Indira Nagar
- DakshinaChitra

Yesterday's Winners

- Vahidha Begum
- Sivasankar K
- Kalathuru Nitheeswar

Chennai is Chennaiing

*T&C apply.

OBITUARY & REMEMBRANCE

DEATH

MR.B.SIVAKUMAR (65), father of Dr. S. Leelavathy, Singaperumal Koil - 603204, expired on 15/08/2026. Eyes donated to Rotary Rajan Eye Bank (Project of Rotary Club of Madras T.Nagar), Chennai-17.(Ph: 28340500)

Smt Rajalakshmi (95)
Attained Acharyan Thiruvadi on **August 14, 2026**. She is survived by her husband **Kasturi Rangan** and children - **Malathi, Srinivasan, Chitralekha, Swaminathan** and **Grandchildren**. Contact 9884275598.

SAD DEMISE

Dr. Hema Krishnan
DOB: 29.10.1971 - DOD 14.08.2026
Associate Professor & Head, Department of Languages (Self - Supporting) 1995 to 2026
Ethiraj College for Women
Mourning by
The Chairman, Board of Trustees, Principal, Present & Past Faculty & Students of Ethiraj College for Women Chennai - 600008

In Loving Memory of

Mrs. L. PADMALAKSHMI
DOB: 7th August 1945
With profound sorrow, we announce the passing of our beloved mother and grandmother, Mrs. Padmalakshmi, wife of Mr. K. Lokabhiram, who peacefully departed from this world on 17th August 2026, at the age of 81.
With heartfelt love and remembrance, Her Children & Grandchildren
Tanuja Rajan : +919840185164
Nitesh : +919600012319

REMEMBRANCE

1st Death Anniversary

Narayanan T.T
Retd. Deputy General Manager Vishakapatnam Steel Plant, RINL. 01.08.1964 - 18.08.2025
Grieved and loved by:
Sudha Narayanan (Wife)
Sapna Narayanan (Daughter)
Bharathwajan S (Son-in-law)
Aadhya Bharadwaj (Granddaughter) and relatives.
A year on, and without you time still feels frozen and the house too quiet. You are no longer beside us, but you watch over us always and will forever remain in our hearts.

DEATH ANNIVERSARIES

ELEVENTH YEAR REMEMBRANCE

LT.COL.K.S.RAJAN, EME

Time may pass, but our love, memories, and gratitude for you remain unchanged. You are always in our hearts and never far from our thoughts.
Prem, Gayti & Harsh

THIRD ANNIVERSARY

SRI. R. RAJASEKARAN
Chartered Accountant
03.01.1946 - 18.08.2023
Fondly Remembered by
R. Swaminathan & Family
Ph: 99406 13993

IN MEMORY OF YOUR LOVED ONES

To dedicate a space in this section, Please contact: **044-28576300** from 10.00 a.m. to 6.00 p.m.
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A CH-CHE

INFRASTRUCTURE LIMITED
(B-SMILE)
Line-02, Bengaluru Smart
City, 30/1, Thimmaiah Road,
Kannur Nagar, Bengaluru-560051
26-27 Date: 17.08.2026

BIDDING TENDER
Bengaluru Smart City
(B-SMILE)
for Two Cover System)

has constituted "Bengaluru
(B-SMILE) for implementation of
city of Bengaluru. On behalf
Limited (B-SMILE), The
Smart Infrastructure Limited
eligible entities / consortia for
operation, maintenance
and

Build Own Operate Transfer
(BOT) on (Duration will be the
same with the RFP and the
particulars of the Project / Works

the work

from Marenahalli Main
to Kanakapura Main Road
(Thalaghattapura junction) in
the Mode - Dynamic Duration,
1. Estimated Project Cost
is: 2,283.19 Cr (including
acquisition & utility Shifting
costs) 2. Support (VGF Amount - 40%
of Security Deposit: 11.42
Cr) 3. Payment Balance through
bank transfer Period: 30 Months
()

for events for Tendering:
1. Issuance of Tender Documents
on: 09.08.2026 (2) Last date for
submission: 21.09.2026 upto 4:30 p.m.
3. Bidding: 02.09.2026, 3:00 p.m.
4. Opening of response to pre-bid queries
on: 05.09.2026 (5) Bid due date (Last
date): 23.09.2026 upto 4:30
p.m. (6) Bid Security / Power of
Attorney to be submitted for opening of
Bids: 24.09.2026 (7) Opening of Financial bid:
25.09.2026

and/
Engineer-2
Infrastructure Limited (B-SMILE)

प्रमुख सरकार				
कार्यपालक अभियंता का कार्यालय				
ग्राम तहसी, एल०सी० रोड, धनबाद				
वेदा आमंत्रण सूचना				
IN/NBAD/26-27				
दिनांक :- 17.08.2026				
कार्य प्रमण्डल, धनबाद द्वारा निम्न विवरण के अनुसार e-procurement				
नाम	प्राक्कलित राशि (लाख में)		कार्य समाप्ति की अवधि	टेण्डर कॉल संख्या
	अंक में	अक्षर में		
1. फुसर्गंगा भागा 5 और पूर्वांगीही), हेला 00सी00सी सड़क निर्माण	102.951	एक करोड़ दो लाख पंचानवे हजार एक सौ	09 माह	प्रथम
नगर में मेन रोड से गली नम्बर 4 तालाब सड़क एवं नाली तथा कोलोनी में भयाम 3, 5 तक, युनिवर्सिटी 4, 05 में एवं लिंक गली निर्माण	117.161	एक करोड़ सतरह लाख सोलह हजार एक सौ	09 माह	प्रथम
इट मैरज हॉल से मूली दूध तक अमन सोसाइटी सड़क का जीर्णोद्धार कार्य	119.483	एक करोड़ उनीस लाख अठ्ठात्तर हजार तीन सौ	09 माह	प्रथम
नगर में काली मंदिर से तालाब से मूलन धौड़ा दुर्गा मंदिर तक ध्व निर्माण	135.117	एक करोड़ पैंतीस लाख ग्यारह हजार सात सौ	09 माह	प्रथम
नगर कोलोनी में हिमाशु क अपार्टमेंट होते हुए एवं पंचपुर नगर कुंज क एवं नाली निर्माण	138.664	एक करोड़ अड़सीस लाख छियासठ हजार चार सौ	09 माह	प्रथम
नगर में पी0सी0सी0 रोड से लीनगर मोड़ से बरवाड़ा 3, 4 में सत्यम नगर नगर कोलोनी में सड़क से आदिवासी बस्ती होते क नाली निर्माण	149.129	एक करोड़ उनचास लाख बारह हजार नौ सौ	09 माह	प्रथम
डेम तक पथ निर्माण	99.885	नितानवे लाख अठासी हजार पाँच सौ	06 माह	प्रथम
ड से मुकरा मुर्ग के घर निर्माण	52.543	बावन लाख चौवन हजार तीन सौ	06 माह	प्रथम

WAY
NOTICE Date: 10.08.2026
Divisional Electrical Engineer
tenders through online
-A: Provision of new RRD
pairing work in existing TRD
Shifting of OHE depot and
mobility of Tower wagon/staff.
and commissioning sewagege
nderADEN/CNB
urity: Rs. 1,37,400/-only
pletion period: - 06 months
(rs.). Tenderer will submit the
(...). Complete details & for
ndian Railway website
1879/26 (D)
s.gov.in @ CPONCR

சிந்தி நிறுவனம்

சிந்தி

ORGANISATION

சர்க்கார், இந்திய அரசு



भारत सरकार

Min. Govt. of India

Regional Office, Sriperumbudur

3, Rajaji Salai, West Tambaram,

Chennai - 600 045

Phone Number: 1800 425 6749

www.mgov.in

Sriperumbudur; Website: epfo.gov.in

E

148B(7) OF THE EMPLOYEE'S

PROVISIONS ACT, 1952.

1952 under the Employee's

1952 in exercise of powers

by submon the Employer of

under Section 148B(7) of

the Commissioner (Assessing Officer)

having Information of the

can appear personally or

or via

e	14B/7Q Period of Inquiry
	01/04/2019 TO 31/03/2024
APFC	
igned have the same powers force the attendance of any ecting Assessing Officer on he above said address. Any ceeding within the meaning section 196 of Indian Penal uthority on the said date/time/ uiry authority may conclude	
Sd/ istant P.F. Commissioner tial Office, Srirambudur	

UPPLIES CORPORATION LTD.
(Odisha Undertaking)
Nayapalli, Bhubaneswar-751012
0674-2395291, Website: www.oscsc.in

PROPOSAL (RFP)

...s & Maintenance and Other Services of
...s (except in-built L1 Scanner presently
...partment / OSCSC Ltd, installed at Fair
of Odisha State along with existing e-Pos
...ement '

TSC, dated : 17.08.2026

Interested bidders being registered under
operation since last 5 years prior to the date
of registration certificates and eligibility as per the
criteria specified in www.tendersodisha.gov.in
for Selection of Agency for Operations &
123000 numbers of e-Pos Devices (except
under warranty) of FS & CW Department /
& RRCs in all 30 Districts of Odisha State
& Database Management'. The details

Date & Time
From 19-08-2026
To 28-08-2026 at 1600 Hours, at Office of OSCSC Ltd., C/2, Nayapalli, Bhubaneswar-751012
To 03-10-2026, through e-procurement Portal www.tendersodisha.gov.in
To 05-10-2026 at 1600 Hours, at Office of OSCSC Ltd. C/2, Nayapalli, Bhubaneswar-751012
To 08-10-2026 at 1600 Hours, at Office of OSCSC Ltd., C/2, Nayapalli, Bhubaneswar-751012
To 14-10-2026 at 1600 Hours, at Office of OSCSC Ltd., C/2, Nayapalli, Bhubaneswar-751012.
...change in the scheduled date will be intimated to Technically Qualified Bidders through online & registered mail ID.
...online through e-Procurement Portal : ...y reserves the right to cancel any or the ...any reason thereof.
-Sd/- Managing Director, OSCSC Ltd.

OIPR-7001/7002/1/26-27/0009

MINES COMPANY LIMITED	
Unit of Karnataka Undertaking) , Karnataka State, Ph: (08537)276339/275463 .com website: www.hutti.gold.karnataka.gov.in	
NO.16/26-27 Dt: 18.08.2026	
P Portal only)	
anager (Materials)" for the following Tenders as	
ation	EMD in Rs.
8 R25, 315/70 R15, 17.5 R25, 16	5,79,000/-
Media Balls.	6,12,000/-
upply, Erection, Installation, Integrate, haft Double Drum Winder.	6,35,000/-
46	
om): 26.08.2026 for SI.No.1 at 11.00 A.M. for M. (2) Last date for receipt of tender: 19.09.2026 09.2026 at 10.00 A.M. signed to log on to website https://www.kppnp.in igned during working hours. For participating in in KPP Portal. -/ The Ic Deputy General Manager (Materials) RODUCER IN INDIA	

CITY RUNS

SAGRAND
building aspirations

Presents

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THE **MAHATMA** HINDU

Co-powered by

AU AU SMALL FINANCE BANK

In association with

Bank of India

Joyalukkas
World's Finest Jeweller

ANDHRA PRADESH
TOURISM

Official Partner

Overseas Education Partner

Food Partner

Hydration Partner

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StudyIn

M **gurudev** **WILLIAMS** **MURUGAN** **RAM**

Bisleri

BIG **10**



The ‘proud Assamese’ from other States

Decoding India's growth in merchandise exports

A refining-led boom in exports

FROM THE ARCHIVES

The Hindu.

Archaeological dept. staff's plea on quarters

New era in navigation



Irani, Ram Madhav, Goyal get key roles in BJP’s new national team

Deepak Mhaskey replaces Amit Malviya as social media head; 12 women are part of the new team named by Nitin Nabin; of the 64 office-bearers, 42 are below age of 60; the group signals continuity and organisational experience in key posts

Nistula Hebbar
NEW DELHI

Seven months after he took charge as the Bharatiya Janata Party chief, Nitin Nabin on Monday unveiled his national organisational team.

Although peppered with some new faces, the team signals continuity and organisational experience in major positions, the return of some important party leaders, and a clear imprint of recent events, including the Gen Z protests, on appointments related to the party’s social media communications.

Former Union Minister Smriti Irani has returned to the organisational team as a general secretary, while Ram Madhav, who served as a general secretary during Amit Shah’s tenure as party chief, has been appointed vice-president.

The inclusion of former Tripura Chief Minister Biplob Deb and Rajya Sabha member Satish Poonia as general secretaries signals that they have been rewarded for their work during the West Bengal and Haryana elections, respectively.



Big appointments: Senior leaders Smriti Irani and Ram Madhav made a comeback to the BJP organisational team. FILE PHOTOS



Only two general secretaries in the previous team have been retained – Sunil Bansal and Vinod Tawde. The new general secretaries include former Lok Sabha member from Uttar Pradesh Harish Dwivedi, Rajya Sabha member Sanjay Bhatia, and Gajendra Patel from Madhya Pradesh.

The appointment with the most sharp signalling, however, appears to be in the BJP’s social media team. After a long stint, Amit Malviya will no longer be in charge. Deepak Mhaskey from Chhattisgarh replaced him.

The appointment of Union Minister for Commerce Piyush Goyal as treasurer

(a post he held from 2010-14), thus holding two posts, one in the government and another in the party organisation, is also significant.

Mr. Mhaskey managed the social media team for the BJP in Chhattisgarh when Mr. Nabin was the State in-charge during the 2023 Assembly election, which the party won. A new team made up of Priti Gandhi, Alok Bhatt, Shivanand Dwivedi, and Arun Yadav is expected to provide a relook to the BJP’s online strategy after the lacerations to the party’s image during the Gen Z protests in July.

Although considered relatively young for the national president’s post, Mr.

Nabin has clearly left his imprint on the team, inducting several figures who enjoyed his trust before his elevation to the top party post.

Media cell

The BJP’s media cell, meanwhile, saw both continuity and change, with Anil Baluni, MP from Uttarakhand, retained as the chief. He will be assisted by Pradeep Bhandari, Ashish Agarwal, and Siddharth Yadav.

The BJP’s expansion, and the splitting of other parties with people joining from there, have also been kept in mind. Sandeep Pathak, formerly of the Aam Aadmi Party, and Rohan Gupta, who joined from the Congress, are now BJP national secretaries. Some of the new faces among the national secretaries include Swadesh Singh, Siddharth Shambhu, and Phangnon Konyak, a Rajya Sabha MP from Nagaland.

The all important position of general secretary (organisation) saw continuity with the retention of B.L. Santhosh, along with Shiv Prakash and Saudan

Singh. All *morcha* or cell chiefs have been changed, with Lok Sabha member from Madhya Pradesh and former chief of the State V.D. Sharma being made the coordinator for all the cells.

The immediate challenge for the new team will be the upcoming Assembly elections in Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Punjab, and Goa. Amid talk that the new team should have a generational shift, the retention of several incumbents signals that Mr. Nabin is proceeding with caution.

Of the 64 office-bearers announced on Monday, six are below the age of 40, while 15 are between the ages of 40 and 49, and 21 between the ages of 50 and 59. There are 12 women among the office-bearers, including six vice-presidents. Around 40% of the team comes from marginalised communities.

The new team appears to strike a balance between the exigencies of immediate political challenges and the fact that this would also be the team under which the BJP will face the 2029 Lok Sabha election.

Thrust into spotlight, Mhaskey banks on ‘reels’ to reach youth

Shubhomoy Sikdar
RAIPUR

Deepak Mhaskey – who was named the BJP’s national social media convenor on Monday – is seen as a strong backroom figure in his home State of Chhattisgarh. However, taking up a bigger role at a time when the party is being forced back to the drawing board to connect with the youth, the spotlight is expected to be on him and his team.

Soon after Mr. Mhaskey’s name was announced, the 58-year-old chemistry professor-turned-politician was asked how he would engage with the youth, to which he replied that it would be through “reels” and that the youth were already on social media and the party would try to reach them through the same.

The reply was in his own mild-mannered style, one that has drawn comparisons with his long-serving predecessor Amit Malviya who was known to be more aggressive. Mr. Mhaskey, who has served as a State-level spokesperson and had headed the State social media cell in the past, was known as someone who was not very regular on TV debates and



Deepak Mhaskey

one who presented the party’s point of view on local media steadily but calmly.

‘Can shift gears’

Those who have worked with him, however, say that he may come across as unassuming but can shift gears when needed.

While Mr. Mhaskey spoke of busting propaganda after the appointment, the BJP that has been ruling the country for over 12 years is facing questions on governance. Party colleagues say that he has been dealing with social media for over 12 years and that makes him suitable for the role. Even Mr. Malviya, when he first took over as the social media chief had lesser experience as a BJP member, they say, even as they underline the need for a more balanced approach in current times.

Congress steps up attack on NTA over UGC-NET re-test

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Congress on Monday stepped up its attack on the National Testing Agency (NTA) over its decision to re-conduct the UGC-NET examination for three subjects, demanding accountability for what it termed “serious” lapses in the examination system and a white paper on 15 major examinations cancelled or postponed by the agency.

The party’s latest attack comes ahead of the Congress Working Committee (CWC) meeting on Wednesday, where expanding the party’s engagement

Jairam Ramesh questioned why candidates should bear consequences of the NTA’s errors

with students and youth through the “*Chhatron Ki Goonj*” (Voice of Students) campaign is expected to be a key agenda. The CWC is also expected to discuss preparations for the next round of Assembly elections.

Congress leader Jairam Ramesh questioned why candidates should bear the consequences of errors in a national-level examination. “Why should the

country’s students bear the punishment for NTA’s mistakes?” he asked in a post on X.

The NTA had announced that it will re-conduct the UGC-NET examinations for English, Commerce and Sociology on September 9 and 10 due to errors in the question papers. Mr. Ramesh questioned the delay in identifying errors, pointing out that the examination was held in June. He said results for candidates who appeared in the other 84 subjects were also being delayed, potentially affecting admissions, Junior Research Fellowships (JRF), and Ph.D. admissions.

Education Minister tells NTA to audit exam processes, submit corrective action report

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

A day after the National Testing Agency (NTA) announced re-conduct of the University Grants Commission – National Eligibility Test (UGC-NET) papers for Sociology, Commerce, and English, Union Education Minister Pralhad Joshi on Monday held a meeting with NTA officials in which he was apprised about steps being taken to reform the education system.

The Minister told the NTA to conduct a thorough audit of all exam processes and submit a report on corrective action taken.

Mr. Joshi was informed that “in the wake of recent issues”, the NTA has removed more than 50 staff and advertised for 10 new professional leadership positions.

The Union Minister told the NTA officials that strict compliance of established exam protocols must be ensured. He directed a complete overhaul of the confidential operations architecture. The revamp includes setting up of secluded rooms, air-gapped systems, and device-deposit protocols for persons handling confidential information on setting of question papers.



Taking stock: Union Minister Pralhad Joshi during a meeting at the Ministry of Education in New Delhi on Monday. X/EDUMINOINDIA

Air-gapped systems are computers or networks that are physically and wirelessly isolated from unsecured networks such as the internet. The sys-

tems have no Wi-Fi, Bluetooth or wired connections which make remote cyberattacks nearly impossible. These systems are used in nuclear power plants, elec-

tric grids, military networks, and financial systems.

‘Checks and balances’

“Domain specialists are being brought in from the private sector for cyber-security, psychometrics, question-paper design and other specialised areas,” an official said.

“We are putting in place checks and balances around paper-setting protocols. The CBI investigations have pointed out gaps where the experts were the once leaking the papers. So, we are working on closing such gaps,” the official added.

No excessive force used; ‘trapped’ constable fired AK-47: Bihar Police to SC

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

The Bihar Police told the Supreme Court in an affidavit on Monday that a police constable “trapped” in the crowd during the Bihar students’ NEET-UG paper leak protests and ensuing violence fired four rounds from his AK-47 rifle in the air.

“No one was injured from the bullets of the AK-47,” the affidavit said.

Though agreeing that the AK-47 is a “platoon-level weapon used in special operations” and not used in “law-and-order situations”, the police still maintained that excessive force was not used and the crowd was met with “utmost restraint”.

The affidavit said another police officer had fired his 9mm pistol to “disperse the mob”. The police admitted that “three protesters suffered minor firearm injuries” without explaining whether they were injured in the 9mm pistol shooting or separately.

The affidavit clarified that the injuries were, however, not caused by the AK-47. The

injured protesters were given the “best possible treatment”, the police said.

“Ballistic examination is being carried out to ascertain the type of weapon, distance of fire, angle of fire, etc,” the affidavit said.

The police said that detailed instructions regarding the use of AK-47 have already been issued by the Director-General of Police on August 1, ostensibly to prevent such incidents. “Thus, it is respectfully submitted that the State and its agencies have maintained utmost restraint and have not used any disproportionate force to cause any harm to the protesters,” the affidavit said.

On the other hand, it pointed out that protesters have severely damaged public property, and officials involved in maintaining law and order were deliberately attacked by anti-social elements who joined the protest.

The police said electronic evidence, have been preserved.

The police said it was not taking coercive measures against students without any criminal antecedents.

Meet protesting students, Rahul says in letter to Jharkhand CM

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

Congress leader Rahul Gandhi has urged Jharkhand Chief Minister Hemant Soren to personally meet students protesting alleged irregularities in State recruitment examinations.

In a letter dated August 14, Mr. Gandhi said the students’ demands were legitimate, and their peaceful protest deserved the government’s support. The Congress is a part of the JMM-led State government.

The Congress leader alleged that the education system had been “captured by the RSS and the BJP” and turned into a tool for “exploitation and oppression” of students. It was no longer, he said, the robust knowledge system it had been a decade ago.

The students’ protest had been peaceful and their demands legitimate, he said.

Mr. Gandhi suggested that Mr. Soren personally meet representatives of the protesting students, saying such a meeting would help reinforce the government’s commitment to resolving their remaining concerns.

Rajasthan bars entry of outsiders at schools amid CJP campaign

The Hindu Bureau
JAIPUR

The Bharatiya Janata Party government in Rajasthan has imposed a restriction on outsiders entering government schools and barred photography and videography without written approval, while citing the “safety and privacy” of students. The abrupt decision triggered a political row in the State on Monday.

The move came shortly after the protests were staged in some schools over dilapidated buildings, shortage of teachers and lack of basic facilities. Activists of the Cockerroach Janta Party (CJP) joined an agitation by students and villagers in a school at Thanagazi in Alwar district on August 14, forcing the authorities to accede to their demands.

While the CJP announced that it would inspect all schools functioning in a poor condition as part of its ‘*School Thik Karo*’ campaign, the Secondary Education Department issued a circular on Sunday evening declaring the restrictions and affirmed that the State government had the

Under the directions, no outsider will be allowed to enter a school campus without prior permission

responsibility of children under the principle of ‘*in loco parentis*’ (in the place of a parent).

Under the directions, no outsider, except a government official duly authorised for official duties, will be allowed to enter a school campus without prior permission of the principal or head of the institution.

Photography restricted

The circular stated that no photography or videography would be permitted without prior written approval of the principal.

Reacting sharply to the government orders, CJP co-convenor Ashutosh Ranka said on X, “You can even arrest us in advance. It is your government, your police. But we will not stop inspecting the schools until all of them are fixed.”



GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
OFFICE OF THE CHIEF CONSTRUCTION ENGINEER, BALANGIR (R&B) CIRCLE, BALANGIR
e-Procurement Notice - BID IDENTIFICATION No.CCE(R&B)BGR/04/2026-27
Letter No.2368//Dtd.14.08.2026

The Chief Construction Engineer, Balangir (R&B) Circle, Balangir on behalf of Governor of Odisha invites percentage rate bid in double cover system in **ONLINE MODE** for the construction of works detailed in the table below from “A” & “B” Class Contractor registered with the State Governments and contractors of equivalent Grade/ Class registered with Central Government/ MES/ Railways for execution of Civil works. The proof of registration from the appropriate authority shall be enclosed along with the bid.

1. Nature of Work : Road Work

2. No. of tender : Total Works - 7 Nos.

3. Tender Cost : Rs.10,000/-

4. Class of Contractor : “A” & “B” Class

5. Date & Time of sale & Receipt of Bids : From Dt.20.08.2026, 06.55 P.M. to Dt.04.07.2026 up to 5.00 P.M.

6. Date of Opening of Bid : Dt.06.07.2026 at 11.00 A.M.

7. The Bidders have to participate in ONLINE bidding only. Further details can be seen from the website: <http://tendersorissa.gov.in>. All future corrigendum will be available on ONLINE MODE only.

Chief Construction Engineer, Balangir (R&B) Circle, Balangir.
34001/644/2627
OIPR-34001/34131/1/26-27/0010



GOVERNMENT OF ODISHA
OFFICE OF THE SUPERINTENDING ENGINEER, MINOR IRRIGATION DIVISION, BALANGIR
WOMEN'S COLLEGE CHOWK, PALACE LINE, DIST-BALANGIR, PIN-767001
ODISHA INTEGRATED IRRIGATION PROJECT FOR CLIMATE RESILIENT AGRICULTURE (OIIPRA) (WORLD BANK PROJECT ID: PI63533)
REQUEST FOR BIDS (RFB) E Procurement Notice
NATIONAL OPEN COMPETITIVE PROCUREMENT FOR SMALL WORKS
RFB No. OIIPRA-W2-BGR-2/2026-27 Date. 14.08.2026

Name of work	Balance work for 'Improvement (Renovation)' to Mayabati MIP in Patangchik Block of Balangir District under OIIPRA. Package ID: BGR-8 of 1(One) Minor Irrigation Project"
No. of Works	01 Minor Irrigation Project
Estimated Cost	Rs.225.26 Lakh Approx.
Cost of Bid Document	Free of Cost
Period of Completion	As per DTCN
Availability of Bid documents	From 19.08.2026 from 10.00 Hrs to 18.09.2026 up to 15.00 Hrs. in the e-Procurement website. (https://tendersodisha.gov.in)
Date of Pre-Bid Meeting	24.08.2026 As per Para-7 of DTCN
Last date & time of receipt of bid	Up to 18.09.2026, 15.00 Hrs. through online
Period of receipt of bid security	To be paid online along with the bid. Bank Guarantees also acceptable subject to verification.
Date of opening of technical bid	On dt.: 19.09.2026 at 11.00 Hrs.
Date of opening of financial bid	To be intimated online after off-line evaluation of Technical Bid.
Digital Signature Certificate of Bidder	The bidder must possess compatible digital signature certificate (DSC) of Class-II or III.

The detail tender call notice can also be seen in the DOWR web site- <https://dowr.odisha.gov.in>; <https://cdtms.in>
Name & Address of the OIT
Superintending Engineer, M.I. Division, Balangir, Women's college chowk, Palace Line, Dist.: Balangir, Pin 767001.
E-Mail:- mid_balangir@yahoo.co.in

Further details can be seen from the e-Procurement market place in : <https://tendersodisha.gov.in>
32001/702/2627
Superintending Engineer, M.I.Circle, Balangir
OIPR-32001/32550/1/26-27/0004



A CH-CHE

The Gujarat Police on Monday reportedly seized devices belonging to independent journalist Ravi Nair, acting on a search warrant issued by a magistrate court. The police also seized a laptop and an iPad belonging to Mr. Nair's colleague Sachi Hegde, who was at his residence at the time, as well as devices reportedly belonging to Mr. Nair's son, as per media reports. As reported in a section of the media, the police reached Mr. Nair's Kerala and Delhi premises in the afternoon. In Kerala, they seized his old and unused phones and pen drives, while in Delhi, his son's laptop, as well as the laptop and iPad of his colleague Ms. Hedge, were impounded.

Petitioners, who include activists and community members, had said the importance of the transgender identity cards cannot be trifled away by the Union government. The petitioners had argued that the 2026 Amendment Act, which came into force on March 30, has dangerously allowed the state unfettered authority to determine gender identity.

FAITH

Hanuman's devotion

The Ramayana holds a revered place. Poet Thulasidas explains that the very purpose of Hanuman's incarnation was to serve Lord Rama. Sri Akkarakkani Srinidhi said in a discourse that Uttara Ramayana admirably shows Hanuman's devotion, intelligence and courage through his journey to Lanka to find Sita. Sage Agastya remarked that Lord Hanuman has qualities such as *sauryam* (heroism and valour), *dakshyam* (skill and efficiency), *balam* (extraordinary strength), *dhairyam* (courage) and *prajna* (wisdom). Lord Hanuman is known as Sundaram.

When Hanuman was a boy, he thought the sun was a ripe fruit and, wanting to eat it, leaped towards the sun. Indra then hit him with his Vajrayudha, wounding his jaw (*hanu*). It is customary to associate Hanuman's name with this incident. His father Vayu Deva became angry. The gods granted Hanuman many boons, after which he acquired extraordinary strength, speed, intelligence, courage, brahmacharya, and divine powers. More significant than his physical strength was his faithful devotion to Lord Rama. Hanuman's role as a messenger for Lord Rama in the search of Sita was important. The wise and old Jambavan realised that only Hanuman had the strength and ability to cross the wide ocean, reach Lanka, find Sita. On his journey across the ocean, Hanuman encountered many obstacles such as Mainaka mountain, Surasa (the mother of Nagas), who tested his intelligence and capabilities, and Simhika, a demoness who could seize a person by capturing their shadow. Nevertheless, Hanuman reached the Ashoka Vana, where he found Sita and presented Rama's ring as a proof.

INBRIEF



Ather Energy intensifies EV bike exports to Nepal

Buoyed by a positive response in Nepal, Bengaluru-based Ather Energy said on Monday that it will launch the Ather 450X Overtones Series in the Himalayan nation. Ather entered Nepal in November 2023 with the 450 Series, marking its first international market. Since then, the company has built out its presence across the country through 14 experience centres and 31 fast charging points via its national distributor, Vaidya Energy, the company said.

Sun Pharma gets favourable verdict in U.S. antitrust litigation

Sun Pharmaceutical Industries on Monday said The United States Court of Appeals for the Third Circuit had passed a judgment in favour of the company and its subsidiaries in the antitrust litigation, in the U.S., relating to a 2008 patent litigation settlement agreement with Pfizer concerning generic Lipitor (Atorvastatin). The appellate court has also affirmed the District Court’s orders denying class certification as to the plaintiffs, the generic drugmaker said.

Rupee falls 19 paise to close at 95.61 against U.S. dollar

The rupee depreciated 19 paise to close at 95.61 against the U.S. dollar on Monday, amid weak domestic equity markets and a surge in crude oil prices. Forex traders said the USD/INR pair is likely to trade with a slight negative bias, pressured by the delay in the deal between the U.S. and Iran, rising crude oil prices and broader dollar support. At interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 95.50 against the greenback and traded in a range of 95.49-95.68.

CEA says bring back lower-ethanol petrol

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

India should bring back a petrol variant with a lower ethanol blend to protect millions of older vehicles, according to a government adviser, marking one of the strongest calls yet from a senior official for greater consumer choice amid growing concerns over the country’s ethanol policy. E20 petrol, with 20% ethanol has been the only petrol variant available for sale at fuel stations across India since April 1. Some users, particularly of non-BS-VI vehicles, have, however, reported a drop in vehicular performance and damage to auto parts – a claim the government repeatedly



V. Anantha Nageswaran

dismissed. Chief economic advisor V. Anantha Nageswaran, alongside Akash Poojari, a consultant in the Department of Economic Affairs, in an opinion piece said the evidence did not support widespread claims that E20 damages vehicle engines, but argued the policy could pose problems for India’s large fleet of older two-wheelers.

Juniper Hotels mulls ₹2,000-crore expansion

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

Juniper Hotels Ltd, a joint venture between Saraf Hotels and Hyatt Hotels Corporation, has outlined plans to invest ₹2,000 crore as it eyes doubling room inventory to more than 4,000 keys by FY31, said CEO Varun Saraf. The firm is pursuing its “Juniper 2.0” growth strategy through which it plans to add five new hotels by FY31, he said. Juniper Hotels expects to fund the ₹2,000-crore capital expenditure through internal accruals and also plans to expand through acquisitions.

India set for record soyoil import on Russia-Ukraine war

Reuters
MUMBAI

India’s soyoil imports are set to hit a record high in August as competitive prices prompt refiners to boost purchases for festive demand, while disruptions to sunflower oil shipments due to the Russia-Ukraine war push buyers to switch oils, dealers said. Soyoil imports in August may rise to 6,20,000 metric tonne, almost 46% above the average monthly import of 4,24,549 tonne so far in the current marketing year which began in November, said four traders involved in trade deals. The traders did not wish to be named in line with company policies.



Women remove weeds from soybean crop in Bhopal, MP.

“Soyoil prices are very competitive. At the same time, there are disruptions to sunflower oil shipments. That is making soyoil even more attractive,” said Sandeep Bajoria, CEO, Sunvin Group, a Mumbai-based vegetable oil brokerage. In recent months, Rus-

sia and Ukraine have increasingly targeted each other’s port and maritime infrastructure in and around the Black Sea, disrupting grain and vegetable oil shipments and reducing export capacity.

Sunflower oil to drop Russia and Ukraine account for most of India’s sunflower oil imports, which may fall to 1,80,000 metric tonne in August, the lowest since February and down 28% from July, dealers said. About 1,50,000 tonne of sunflower oil originating from the Black Sea and scheduled for shipment in August and September have been delayed because of the conflict, another dealer said.

The Hindu Bureau
BENGALURU

India’s six publicly listed Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs) have collectively distributed ₹3,136 crore to over 4.85 lakh unitholders during Q1 FY27, according to the Indian REITs Association (IRA). The six listed REITs in India are Brookfield India

Real Estate Trust, Embassy Office Parks REIT, Mindspace Business Parks REIT, Nexus Select Trust, Knowledge Realty Trust and Bagmane Prime Office REIT. As of Q1 FY27, the total gross Assets Under Management (AUM) of the Indian REIT sector stood at over ₹3.17 lakh crore, while the combined market capitalisation of the sector

Last week, Mr. Chandrasekaran expressed his desire not to continue after his tenure ended

proved by the board and continuation of N. Chandrasekaran, chairman, as Tata Sons director. Last week, Mr. Chandrasekaran expressed his desire not to continue after his tenure ended in February 2027. A day later, Sir Dorab Tata Trust (SDTT) accepted his decision and initiated the process to look for a successor. Tata Trusts hold 66% in Tata Sons, Shapoorji Pallonji Group 18% and rest by Tata Group firms, Tata family and individuals.

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY) on Monday approved projects collectively worth ₹7,877 crore for incentives under the Electronics Component Manufacturing Scheme (ECMS).

The projects include several electronic parts that have not been manufactured before in India, including electrolyte additives, hermetic terminals (used for defence-grade sealed assemblies), metalised films for capacitors, and coils. The ECMS has so far approved projects collectively worth ₹69,548 crore, and these will receive turnover- or capex-linked incentives upon achieving key milestones. IT firm Wipro’s lami-



IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw and Union MoS Jitin Prasada during handover of Approvals under ECMS on Monday. ANI

nates project had a ₹1,033 crore increase in project value, which is reflected in the project total shared by the Ministry, leaving ₹6,844 crore in approvals for fresh projects. IT Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw said that India was “fully atmanirbhar” (autonomous) in approved projects’ planned supplies of enclosures for devices, relays (which are being exported also), anode material, and optical transceiv-

ers. Laminates are being produced at 80% of domestic demand, with connectors, lithium ion cells and transducers at 75%, 60%, and 55% domestic production respectively. “We are yet to reach the employment target [under the scheme], but we will reach that shortly,” IT Secretary S. Krishnan said in his remarks. “This is one of the fastest moving programmes of the ministry currently, with a large

stood at over \$2.17 lakh crore as of August 11, 2026. Together, the six REITs manage more than 214 million sq. ft of Grade A office

IT Ministry okays ₹7,877-cr. worth projects under ECMS

The projects under the Electronics Component Manufacturing Scheme include several electronic parts that have not been manufactured before in India such as metalised films for capacitors

CAS here to stay, but open to review for improvement: SEBI

Ashokamithran T.
MUMBAI

The new Closing Auction Session (CAS) mechanism for determining closing prices is here to stay, even as the markets regulator remains open to stakeholder feedback and possible tweaks to address any issues.

“CAS is here to stay for sure. We will see if there are certain constraints or certain issues that we can improve,” SEBI Chairperson Tuhin Kanta Pandey said while speaking on the sidelines of the launch of cyber reporting platforms at the NISM campus. He further said that several industry participants had welcomed the move as it provided a single price at which trades could be executed, countering criticism over tracking errors. Under the earlier system, the closing price was derived using the volume-weighted average price (VWAP). However, several market par-



Tuhin Kanta Pandey

ticipants are yet to upgrade their systems which were built around legacy processes and the earlier VWAP-based mechanism. “It is a major microstructure change. When there is something going on for years, people think that it will never come – the change will never come. And then, therefore, they do not give total energy into learning a new system. There are some initial teething problems whenever you come up with something major because people tend to believe that it will be postponed,” Mr. Pandey said.

Six listed Indian REITs distribute ₹3,136 cr. to unitholders in Q1 FY27



THE HINDU

Best Places to Work 2027

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Recognising Winning Workplaces:

Inside The Hindu Best Places to Work Awards, powered by WorkL



Lord Mark Price
Founder, *WorkL*

in conversation with
Mr. Pradeep Gairola
(Chief Digital Business Officer, *The Hindu*)

 **August 19, 2026 (Wednesday)** |  **03:00 p.m. (IST)** |  **Zoom (live)**

The conversation will cover:

- What makes India's **best workplaces stand out**
- Why a **people-first culture** is important to drive business success
- How to **enter the 2027 awards cycle and be recognised** as one of India's Best Places to Work

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WASHINGTON

Trump says Iran should surrender, threatens to bomb Oman: report



U.S. President Donald Trump threatened to bomb Oman if it “gets in the way” of a U.S. deal with Iran on the Strait of Hormuz. “If Oman gets in the way, we’ll bomb the shit out of them,” Mr. Trump told Fox News reporter Trey Yingst. Mr. Trump said that Iran should “put up the white flag of surrender,” according to Mr. Yingst’s post on X. AFP

ERBIL

Iraqi Kurdistan PM’s office targeted in Iranian drone attack, officials say



Two Iranian drones targeted the office of Iraqi Kurdistan Prime Minister Masrour Barzani, and the home of the autonomous region’s intelligence chief overnight, officials said on Monday. Since the start of the West Asia war, the Kurdistan region has been targeted over 1,000 times by Tehran and pro-Iran armed groups inside Iraq. AFP

KINSHASA

Congo’s Ebola outbreak becomes country’s worst; over 2,300 dead



A fast-spreading Ebola outbreak in the Democratic Republic of Congo is now the country’s deadliest ever, with 4,945 cases including 2,325 deaths in three months, government figures showed on Monday. No specific vaccine or treatment exists for the Bundibugyo strain behind the current surge of the disease. AFP

SANAA

Yemen’s Houthi rebels claim attack on Saudi military vessel in Red Sea



Yemen’s Houthi rebels said on Monday they had targeted a Saudi military vessel and four accompanying boats in the Red Sea off the coast of Mokha, “using several ballistic missiles” as part of their maritime blockade of Saudi Arabia that was announced last month. Riyadh did not immediately respond to the announcement. AFP

Trump orders scaling back of joint military exercises with South Korea

Pentagon chief ordered to ‘substantially reduce’ the drills as it was too late to cancel them; U.S. President says military drills send ‘inappropriate and hostile’ signal to North Korea; also claims South Korean President refused to help with Iran war

Agence France-Presse
SEOUL

U.S. President Donald Trump said he ordered the Pentagon to scale back “inappropriate and hostile” military drills with South Korea, hours before the exercises began on Monday.

The U.S. leader cited his “good relationship” with North Korean leader Kim Jong-un in his latest rebuke to long-standing alliances with global partners.

South Korean officials said the exercises had begun as planned and that they hoped the personal chemistry between Mr. Trump and Mr. Kim would bring them back to talks.

Seoul’s Presidential office said it remained in “close coordination” with Washington over the exercises.



Standing ready: U.S. soldiers seen near military vehicles at Camp Humphreys in Pyeongtaek, South Korea, on Monday. AFP

The office “hopes that the friendly relationship between the leaders of the United States and North Korea will lead to meaningful dialogue”.

North Korea has not responded publicly, although it has previously voiced anger at the regular joint manoeuvres that take place in the South.

The drills began as American allies in East Asia fret over North Korean displays of weapons capabilities and its growing alignment with Russia, as well as traditional backer China.

“Based on my very good relationship with Kim Jong Un, of North Korea, I am not happy with the fact

that the United States has, long ago, agreed to participate in Joint Military Exercises with South Korea,” Mr. Trump wrote on his Truth Social platform.

“These exercises are not only costly, with much of these costs paid for by the United States of America (as usual), but send a signal that is totally inappropriate and hostile, to a Country that, as long as Donald J. Trump has been President, has been unthreatening and respectful,” he said.

He took direct aim at South Korea, writing: “I recently asked the President of South Korea if they would like to join us in the Denuclearisation of the Islamic Republic of Iran, and they said, ‘No thanks!’”

Mr. Trump said he had ordered Defence Secretary Pete Hegseth to “substan-

tially reduce” the drills because it was too late to cancel them.

‘Inane decision’
Meanwhile, Jack Reed, the top U.S. Senate Democrat on military affairs, described Mr. Trump’s order as “inane”, and said China and Russia were “watching how easily this President abandons America’s allies”.

“This is another inane, haphazard decision by President Trump and his chaotic administration,” the Senate Armed Services Committee ranking member said in a statement.

The 11-day Ulchi Freedom Shield exercises are designed to prepare for a possible war with North Korea. Pyongyang, however, decries the drills as dress rehearsals for an invasion.

Russia targets Ukraine’s port infrastructure in new strikes

Reuters
KYIV

A Russian attack targeted port infrastructure in Ukraine’s Izmail district in the southern region of Odesa overnight, Ukrainian authorities said on Monday.

Fires caused by the attack have been extinguished, the authorities added on the Telegram messaging app.

Russia’s Defence Ministry said its forces had hit military targets in the port, which it described as “a berthing terminal used for unloading vessels carrying military cargo, hangars housing Western military equipment, and depots for naval drones”.

Izmail, close to the Romanian border, is home to Ukraine’s largest port on the Danube river.

In a separate strike, Russia said its forces had hit a patrol boat and fuel storage tanks in Odesa. The local Governor there said a civilian Togo-flagged vessel



To the sky: An Mi-8 helicopter flies over Ukrainian servicemen as they await parachute training in an undisclosed location. AFP

was damaged and four people were injured.

Energy sites targeted
Meanwhile, Ukraine’s largest oil and natural gas company Naftogaz said on Monday that facilities of the state-owned entity was attacked 13 times over the past week.

Russia has repeatedly battered the Ukrainian power grid since its all-out invasion more than four years ago. Ukrainian officials, who say Russia is “weaponising winter,” fear Moscow will pursue its

campaign through the coming winter, too.

Russian drones and missiles struck facilities in several regions of the country, with one asset hit multiple times during the week, Naftogaz said.

DTEK Group, a coal mining and power production company which says it is the largest private investor in Ukraine’s energy sector, also said a Russian attack started a fire at one of its mines, killing a 52-year-old man.

(With inputs from The Associated Press)

Cambridge head slams ‘racist frenzy’ over dead academic

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

The head of Cambridge university on Monday condemned a “racist feeding frenzy” prompted by plagiarism claims against the black academic Jason Arday, who was found dead last week after resigning from his post.

After Arday, Cambridge’s youngest ever black professor, was found dead on August 14 following multiple plagiarism accusations, Chris Smith, the university’s chancellor,

told the BBC it was important that claims of plagiarism were “rigorously investigated”. But Mr. Smith said it was also right to “refuse to join in a racist feeding frenzy over a particular academic”, without naming Arday directly.

Arday resigned on August 5 after accusations he had plagiarised parts of his doctoral thesis were covered widely by media.

A petition demanding a public inquiry into the media coverage of Arday had gathered almost 32,400 signatures on Monday.

Kushner holds talks with Netanyahu on plan to end Gaza war

Agence France-Presse
JERUSALEM

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and U.S. envoy Jared Kushner discussed putting an American general in charge of verifying Hamas’s disarmament on Monday, an Israeli official said, as the premier insisted there would be no pullout from Gaza until then.

Mr. Kushner, President Donald Trump’s son-in-law, flew to the region after Mr. Netanyahu, facing a tough re-election fight, pu-

blicly rejected the latest part of a U.S. plan aimed at ending the Gaza war.

Mr. Kushner met Mr. Netanyahu in Jerusalem a day after holding rare direct talks with Hamas, which has committed itself to the plan and to disarmament.

The two sides “agreed that no redeployment or reconstruction would take place in the Gaza Strip before Hamas is disarmed”, a senior Israeli official said.

Mr. Kushner was joined in the talks by former British Prime Minister Tony Blair.

Afghanistan consulate in Delhi marks first-ever ‘Taliban victory day’ event

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

Afghanistan has left the era of warfare and has started a journey towards stability and reconstruction under the umbrella of the Islamic system, said the diplomatic representative of the Taliban administration at an event in the Afghanistan embassy in New Delhi that, for the first time, celebrated the 2021 ‘victory’ of the Taliban.

Presenting what he described as Taliban-ruled Afghanistan’s initiatives, Mufi Noor Ahmad Noor, Chargé d’Affaires at the Embassy of Afghanistan, said on Monday that Afghanistan’s territory should not be a space of



Taliban officials Dr. Ikramuddin Kamil and Noor Ahmad Noor in New Delhi on Monday. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

‘competition’ and should serve as an arena of cooperation and connectivity.

“We have left the chapter of war behind and embarked on a new chapter in which Afghanistan, under

prudent and unified leadership and within the framework of the Islamic system, has been taking steps towards stability, reconstruction, economic growth, and the expansion of relations with the world on the basis of mutual respect,” said Mr. Noor in a speech delivered in Pashto.

The reception was attended by diplomats from Russia, U.S., China, Qatar, Libya, Bhutan, Mongolia, Oman and the UAE.

From the Indian side, Anand Prakash, Joint Secretary in-charge of the Pakistan-Afghanistan-Iran (PAI) division of the Ministry of External Affairs, attended the event along with other members of the Ministry.

“Despite the war in the Gulf, India-Afghanistan trade remains around \$1 billion, which is a sign of stability,” said a senior Indian official.

Considering the fact that the Taliban, which does not enjoy full diplomatic recognition by India, was allowed to host a celebration of its ‘Victory Day’ in the Indian capital for the first time, the official said, “Taliban is a reality and we have to engage with them”.

The reception was held against the backdrop of continued engagements between India and the Taliban administration in Kabul that have, in the past two years, clashed with Pakistan on multiple occasions.

TRANSMISSION CORPORATION OF ANDHRA PRADESH LIMITED
(A Government of Andhra Pradesh Undertaking & An ISO 27001-2022 Certified Company)
e-Procurement TENDER NOTICE
The APTRANSCO invites bids online for Spec No. PMMTC3-e-40/2026. Work : “Migration of existing SAP Cloud environment to a new Service Provider Cloud, Hosting and Providing Managed Services for the migrated Cloud environment for a period of 2 Years”. Date & Time of availability of Tender: 18.08.2026 at 18:00 PM. Web: <http://tender.approcurement.gov.in>
RO No: GMCC/APTRANSCO/119/26-27 Sd/- Chief Engineer, TELECOM & IT

Government of Kerala
TENDER
FOREST & WILD LIFE DEPARTMENT
Window No: iprd 26/c 69 • E-auction No: KFDDO/65783/2025-DFO TSPBVR/A2 • Divisional Forest Officer, Timber Sales Division, Perumbavoor, Mudikkal P.O-683547, Phone-0484-2522219 • E-auction of timber on 03/09, 16/09, 19/09, 29/09, 03/10, 08/10, 15/10, 27/10/2026 from Chalukudi, vecetoor, Mudical, Chetikulam & Varapuzha depots of Timber sales division, Perumbavoor • PAC : 4 Crore.
Full details on Tender Advertisement appeared above are exhibited before the Office from which the tender originates. For Details on all Tenders above please visit tender.approcurement.gov.in Please put in search the Window No for getting the advertisement of your choice. R.O. No. 109V/G/2026/PRD.

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Ph: 0484-2846700
E- Tender cum Auction Notice
For Property Development and Lease of Part of Building at Edappally Metro Station (RHS)
E Tender ID : 2026_KMRL_865079_1
Bid submission end date : 01-Sep-2026
Pre-Bid Meeting date : 21-Aug-2026
Tender documents can be downloaded from www.etenders.kerala.gov.in / www.kochimetro.org
Further corrigendum & addendum will be published only on website

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Regd. Office: 10-15/21, 4th Floor, Sri Sai Towers, Besides SIRIS company, Bandar Road, Vijayawada-520007
NATIONAL SHORT TENDER NOTICE
Lt.No.Mktg.M8/RG Dail/Tenders/October/2026 to December/2026 17-08-2026
BIDS ARE INVITED FROM ELIGIBLE BIDDERS FOR SUPPLY OF 2,166,000 MTS (+ or - 25%) OF R.G DALL IN 1 KG PACKET FORM WITH SECONDARY PACKING IN 50 KG NEW POLYPROPYLENE (PP) BAGS UNDER ICDS/THR SCHEMES FOR THE MONTHS OF October/2026 to December/2026 (Three Months) TO ALL THE MLS POINTS OF (28) DISTRICTS IN ANDHRA PRADESH STATE.
All the interested R.G Dail Manufacturers in All Over India may visit www.apscscl.in & www.neml.in to view and download tender documents at free of cost.
Interested bidders need to register in portal as vendor with NCDEX e Markets Limited to participate in the tenders. Contact Tel: 9962059599 or 9032429420 or 9885649722 and Email: askus@neml.in
Last date for registration and completion of formalities for the e-auction shall be up to 26.08.2026 at 5 P.M and the tentative date of online auction through NeML platform would be 28.08.2026 from 11.00 A.M onwards.
K.KANNA BABU, I.A.S
VC & Managing Director

BANGALORE ELECTRICITY SUPPLY COMPANY LIMITED
(Wholly owned by Government of Karnataka undertaking)
(CIN-U04010KA2002SGC030438)
EOI WITHDRAWAL / CANCELLATION
BESCOM had published newspaper notification in THE HINDU (ALL INDIA) & VIJAYAVANI (K) newspapers on date: 11.08.2026 for EOI “Expression of interest to explore lesser transaction charges for selection of sponsor bank for providing National Automated Clearing House (NACH) services for 3 years”. The said EOI has been cancelled and withdrawn.
Sd/-
GENERAL MANAGER (F&R),
BESCOM
For Electricity related complaints call: 1912
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Government of Kerala
Published Tenders from 13-08-2026 to 16-08-2026
Kerala Police
Tender ID: 2026_KP_865360_1 * Inspector General of Police, Cyber Operations * Digitization and Implementation of DMR Tier II system in Nor * Closing Date: 01-Sep-2026 * PAC: Rs234100000
Visit <https://etenders.kerala.gov.in> for more details.
Ro.No:13-16/Aug/2026/PRD/(N)4

BANGALORE WATER SUPPLY AND SEWERAGE BOARD
Office of the Engineer-In-Chief, 2nd Floor, Cauvery Bhavan, K.G. Road, Bengaluru - 560 009.
IFT No: BWSSB/EIC/ACE(CS&DCW)/TA/2566/2026-27 Dated: 14-08-2026
INVITATION FOR TENDER (only through KPP Portal)
BWSSB invites Tenders in Two Stage Tender System from eligible tenderers for the Work of Modernisation & Remodeling of Water supply system and reduction in UFW in Frazer Town-7 coming under AECC-1-2 Sub-Division limit of BWSSB, Bengaluru.
Amount Put to Tender: ₹ 362.97 Lakhs, EMD : ₹ 6.42 Lakhs
The Last date for uploading of completed tender documents is on 02-09-2026 upto 16:00 hrs. The Bids will be Opened on 03-09-2026 at 16:30 hrs. The details regarding the tender and participation in the e-procurement portal process can be obtained by logging on to <https://kppp.karnataka.gov.in>. For further details contact the undersigned office during working hours.
Sd/-
Engineer-in-Chief
DIPR/SI/2198/2026-27

कार्यालय श्री सांवलिया जी मंदिर मण्डल
मण्डफिया, जिला-चित्तौड़गढ़ (राज.)
क्रमांक / लेखा / श्रीसामंमं / 2026-27 / 795 दिनांक-14.08.2026
ई-निविदा सूचना संख्या - 09/2026-27
श्री सांवलियाजी मंदिर मण्डल, मण्डफिया द्वारा निम्नलिखित कार्य हेतु पंजीकृत व योग्य संवेदकों से निर्धारित प्रपत्र में ई-प्रोक्युरमेंट प्रक्रिया के माध्यम से ऑनलाइन निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं। निविदा प्रपत्र, विस्तृत विवरण व अन्य शर्तें <http://sppp.rajasthan.gov.in> तथा <http://eproc.rajasthan.gov.in> पोर्टल पर दिनांक 17/08/2026 को प्रातः 09:00 बजे से उपलब्ध होकर दिनांक 07/09/2026 सायं 06:00 बजे तक ऑन लाईन सबमिट किये जा सकते हैं जिनकी तकनीकी निविदाएं दिनांक 08.09.2026 को दोपहर 12:00 बजे ऑनलाइन खोली जावेगी। निविदा संबंधी शुल्क व राशियां निविदा प्रपत्र में अंकित बैंक खाते में जमा करवानी होगी।
क्र. कार्यों का विवरण अनु.लागत (लाखों में) UBN
1. Repair and Renovation Works at Gokul Vishranti Griha. 300.00 SMM2627W SOB00036
2. Construction of Additional Class Rooms at Various Villages of SSM, Mandfiya 308.00 SMM2627W SOB00037
3. Construction of TEE PEE Shed on the Remaining portion of the Road in front of the Mandir Singh Dwar at Mandfiya. 320.00 SMM2627W SOB00038
4. Various Construction Works in Goshala of S.S.M.M. Mandfiya 500.00 SMM2627W SOB00039
5. Annual Rate Contract for Miscellaneous Civil Works Including Repair, Maintenance, Alteration, Renovation and New work in S.S.M.M., Mandfiya 500.00 SMM2627W SOB00040
मुख्य कार्यपालक अधिकारी
श्री सांवलिया जी मंदिर मण्डल

The fans were an energy-booster for me: Ayush after win over Shi



Jadeja in 350-wicket club, joins elite list to do a rare double



His consistency is world-class: Suthar in awe of senior pro Jadeja



Dinusha credits Dickwella, says plan was not to get bogged down

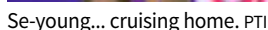


Ayush turns giant-killer, dethrones World No. 1 Shi



Uthra Ganesan
NEW DELHI

Facing the No. 1 challenge



India gains big lead despite Dinusha-Dickwella fightback

K.C. Vijaya Kumar
GALLE

Defiant stand: Dinusha and Dickwella helped the home team avoid the follow-on. PTI

fell to Ravindra Jadeja.

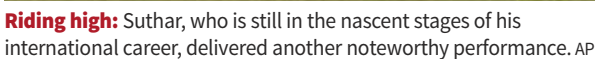
SCOREBOARD

1-0 (Nishan, 0.2), 2-27 (Chandimal, 7.1), 3-53 (Udara, 13.5), 4-59 (Kamindu, 16.1), 5-90 (Dhananjaya, 26.1), 6-236 (Dickwella, 61.4), 7-243 (Nuwantha, 66.4), 8-274 (Prabath, 77.5), 9-274 (Dinusha, 78.1).

Siraj 9-3-29-1, Prasidh 14-0-47-1,
Suthar 21.4-1-76-4, Kuldeep
14-0-65-1, Jadeja 21-5-57-3.

Dhananjaya edged Jadeja and next man Dickwell struck two fours and at lunch, Sri Lanka mustered 99 for five. As the day progressed the host found a foothold even as it unravelled in the final stretch.

He also clarified that issues like the ball going soft and the strong breeze did not affect his rhythm.



K.C. Vijaya Kumar
GALLE

Suthar, who made his debut against Afghanistan earlier this year, grabbed four wickets while his senior colleague gained three. "Our main focus was to get wickets in the first session. We did the same in

A CH-CHE

INBRIEF



Seifert dazzles, Super Giants clinch maiden Hundred title

New Zealand opener Tim Seifert’s blistering innings paved the way for Manchester Super Giants’ five-wicket win over Trent Rockets in the final of the Hundred at Lord’s on Sunday. Seifert smashed 72 off 38 balls, including seven sixes and four fours, to help Rockets chase down a target of 159 with two deliveries to spare. Rockets had tasted success in the preceding women’s final, thrashing 2025 winner Sunrisers Leeds by eight wickets after dismissing their opponents for just 91. Sophia Dunkley made 41 off 23 balls and Beth Mooney struck 31 not out off 21.

Vigensh, Saranya champions; India wins five medals

Vigensh Vemula and Saranya Narahari emerged champions at the Asian junior blitz championship in Mumbai on Monday. India, in fact, claimed five of the six medals on offer. Viresh Sharnarathi and V.S. Nandish won the silver and the bronze in the open section to make it a clean sweep for the host.

The standings (Indians unless specified): 1-3: Vignesh Vemula, Viresh Sharnarathi, V.S. Nandish (6/7); 4-7: Akshay Borgaonkar, Madhvendra Sharma, Imangali Akhilbay (Kaz), Apoorv Kamble (5.5); 8-10: Vivaan Sardana, Shageldi Kurbandurdyev (Tkm), Pratyush Kumar (5). **Girls:** 1. Saranya Narahari (6.5/7); 2. Lala Shoradova (Tkm) 6; 3. Sannidhi Bhat (5.5); 4-10. Prishita Gupta, S. Shanmathi Sree, Anushka Kutwal, V. Tripurambika, B. Krithika, Sravyasree Bheemarasetty V.C. Nivedita (5).

Fernandez’s brace guides Espanyol to facile win

Espanyol striker Roberto Fernandez netted two first-half goals as his side cruised to a 3-0 LaLiga home win over Levante on Sunday.

The results: Espanyol 3 (Fernandez 5, 40, Dolan 80) bt Levante 0; Racing Santander 2 (Martin 21-pen, Martinez 34) drew with Villarreal 2 (Gueye 45, Pepe 45+1).

Karnataka thumps Goa; Bihar beats Tamil Nadu

Karnataka thumped Goa 9-0 in a Division ‘B’ (Pool-B) contest of the 16th Hockey India junior women’s National championship in Pune on Monday. Bihar defeated Tamil Nadu 5-1 another match.

The results: Div. ‘A’: Pool-A: Jharkhand bt Punjab 3-1; **B:** Haryana bt Odisha 3-0; **C:** UP bt Maharashtra 3-0; **D:** MP bt Chhattisgarh 3-1. **Div. ‘B’: A:** Delhi bt Kerala 5-0; Mizoram bt Andhra Pradesh 4-1; **B:** Karnataka bt Goa 9-0; Bihar bt TN 5-1.

LIVE TELECAST

Badminton: World championships, Sports 18-1, 3, JioHotstar & BWF Official YouTube channel, 9 a.m. onwards
Sri Lanka vs India: First Test, Day 4, Sony Sports Ten 1 & LIV, 9.45 a.m.
Hockey World Cup: (Men), SS Select 2, Star Sports First & JioHotstar, 1 p.m. 5.30, 8.30 & 9.30 p.m. (Women): SS Select 2, Star Sports First & JioHotstar, 2.30 p.m. 4 p.m.; India vs South Africa, 6.30 p.m. & 12 a.m. (Wednesday)
TNPL: Sony Sports Ten 4 Tamil & TNPL Official YouTube channel (youtube@tamilnadupremierleague.com), 7.30 p.m.

SNAPSHOTS

Pragg stays joint second after draw with Aronian
ST. LOUIS (USA): R. Pragganandhaa played out a draw with Levon Aronian of the USA in the Sinquefeld Cup’s sixth round on Sunday. With the stalemate, the 21-year-old remained in joint second spot with 3.5 points in the Grand Chess Tour event.
The results (sixth round): Sinquefield Cup: Anish Giri (Ned) 2.5 bt Jorden van Foreest (Ned) 1; Maxime Vachier-Lagrave (Fra) 3.5 drew with Wesley So (USA) 4; Samuel Sevian (USA) 3 drew with Vincent Keymer (Ger) 3.5; R. Pragganandhaa 3.5 drew with Levon Aronian (USA) 3; Javokhir Sindarov (Uzb) 2.5 drew with Fabioano Caruana (USA) 3.
Cairns Cup: Carissa Yip (USA) 3 drew with Bibisara Assaubayeva (Kaz) 3.5; Stavroula Tsolakidou (Gre) 3.5 drew with Divya Deshmukh 3.5; Tan Zhongyi (Chn) 4.5 drew with Alexandra Kosteniuk (Sui) 1; K. Humpy 2 lost to Alice Lee (USA) 4; Anna Muzychuk (Ukr) 3 drew with R. Vaishali 2.
Bagan edges Jamshedpur
KOLKATA: Mohun Bagan Super Giant edged past Jamshedpur FC 9-8 on penalties after being locked 1-1 in regulation time to reach the semifinals of the 135th Durand Cup on Monday.
The results: Quarterfinals: At Kolkata: Mohun Bagan 1 (Sahal Abdul Samad 2) drew with bt Jamshedpur 1 (Devendra Murgaonkar 45). Bagan won 9-8 on penalties **At Shillong:** NEUFC 5 (Alaaeddine Ajarie 11, 58, 69, Etyan Gonzalez 55, Jithin M.S. 79) bt Shillong Lajong FC 2 (Figo Syndai 20, Joao Morais 34).
Vallab eliminates Ayan
CHENNAI: Qualifier Vallab Kumar of USA defeated

England exposes India’s shortcomings

The European side rallies to score a 4-2 win and advances to the second round; Harmanpreet & Co. lack ideas and composure inside the circle

HOCKEY WORLD CUP

Aashin Prasad
AMSTELVEEN

The visuals, under the gloomy skies here at the Wagener Stadion, painted quite the picture.
Late in the third quarter, England came from behind to regain the lead when Henry Croft, under little pressure from Jugraj Singh, had the time and space to receive the ball, take a few touches, turn and fire it past Mohith H.S. Before the restart, the rolling subs were called for and Jugraj, once again, showed no urgency to get off the pitch, forcing head coach Craig Fulton to furiously give him the marching orders.
After the opening day win, where there were still several questions left to be answered, the Indian men’s team failed to come



Turning it around: England pumped in three goals in the span of 16 minutes to dash India’s hopes. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

up with them in its World Cup Pool-D 4-2 defeat at the hands of No. 3-ranked England on Monday.
Coming into the tournament, England boasted the best defensive record of the year. In its 17 matches, it conceded just a goal per

game, a remarkable number by hockey standards.
Yet, India recovered from the Nicholas Bandurak opener to score two, one from a Harmanpreet Singh rocket drag-flick and another from forward Dilpreet Singh, after some

neat work from Hardik Singh and Abhishek Nain by the byline.

Tough going
But as it did in the first quarter, India struggled against England’s man-to-man full court press, which

forced turnovers in compromising areas of the pitch.
England’s pressure paid off in the 38th minute when Stuart Rushmere stretched to get on the end of Liam Sanford’s fired in pass as the ball sailed past

Mohith. A few minutes later, Mohith looked on helplessly as Croft added a third to make it 3-2.
India showed urgency in the fourth quarter, but even as England had two green card penalties, it lacked ideas and composure inside the circle to find a reply.
Killer blow
Bandurak, who had earlier capitalised on a defensive lapse for his first goal, piled on India’s misery when he fired home from a penalty corner to take England to the second round. While India could still reach the next round, this result will only make its path to the semifinals harder.
The Indian women’s team will face off against South Africa on Tuesday.

The result: India 2 (Harmanpreet 16-pc, Dilpreet 24) lost to England 4 (Bandurak 13 & 54-pc, Rushmere 38, Croft 42).

Our defence didn’t do well, admits Fulton

Aashin Prasad
AMSTELVEEN

Head coach Craig Fulton lamented India’s missed opportunities and poor defensive display in the 2-4 reverse against England in its hockey World Cup match here on Monday.
England’s four strikes took the number of goals conceded by India to 44 in 18 games this year.
“The first half was good, but we got caught on the counter-attack [Nicholas Bandurak’s goal]. In the third quarter, we had some big moments but didn’t take them.

Playing like a No. 3
“Unfortunately, our defence didn’t do well. England played like a World No. 3,” said Fulton.
Midfielder Manpreet Singh echoed the coach’s sentiment.
“It is important to have a strong defence when you play against a good team. And it is also important that whenever you get an opportunity, you convert it into a goal,” said Manpreet.
India now needs a win against Pakistan on August 19 (Wednesday) to progress to the second round.
“The boys will be motivated as we need to come out firing against Pakistan. We have to be better on the ball in the final third and need to show composure,” said Fulton.

Caravan moves to Chennai

TNPL

Sankar Narayanan E.H.
CHENNAI

The margin for error is razor-thin after 20 games as the TNPL-10 caravan shifts to Chennai for the business end of the tournament.
Only Net Run Rate (NRR) separates the second-placed team and the fifth-placed outfit as the eight sides arrive here for their last two league fixtures before the knockouts.
Only SKM Salem Spartans, yet to get off the mark after five matches, has failed to get going.
Taking first strike at the M.A. Chidambaram Stadium, on Tuesday, are Chepauk Super Gillies – the team best placed among those with six points – and Vida Kovai Kings, sixth on the table despite boasting the best NRR.

Having the momentum
While Kovai Kings are coming off a 116-run thumping of Trichy Grand Cholas (contributing largely to its superior NRR) on the last day of the Dindigul leg, Super Gillies have landed in Chepauk after consigning Madurai Panthers to its only loss.
Kovai Kings captain Shahrukh Khan acknowledged that his team was in a must-win situation.
“We’re not looking at other teams. We’re in a tough spot after the three



Task cut out: Kovai Kings captain Shahrukh acknowledged that his team was in a must-win situation. R. RAGU



Upbeat: Super Gillies, led by Jagadeesan, are coming off a win over table topper Panthers. R. RAGU

losses. Our focus is to win two games and not look at the run rate. Our NRR is way better than anyone else. And anyway, we will be out of the tournament if we lose,” Shahrukh said on Monday.
‘Not in our control’
When asked if it was a disadvantage to be among the first teams to play in Chennai, Super Gillies skipper N. Jagadeesan explained: “This [the schedule] is not in our control. It is always good to play the next match as soon as possible when you have momentum with you.”
Points table (read as team, played, won, lost, points, NRR):
1. Madurai Panthers 5-4-1-8(+0.290); 2. Chepauk Super Gillies 5-3-2-6(+0.472); 3. Idream Tiruppur Tamizhans 5-3-2-6(+0.222); 4. Nelloai Royal Kings 5-3-2-6(+0.133); 5. Trichy Grand Cholas 5-3-2-6(-0.304); 6. Vida Kovai Kings 5-2-3-4(+1.247); 7. Dindigul Dragons 5-2-3-4(+0.205); 8. SKM Salem Spartans 5-0-5-0(-2.392).
Tuesday’s match: Chepauk Super Gillies vs. Vida Kovai Kings, 7.30 p.m.

Jagadeesan and Shahrukh open up about challenges

Sankar Narayanan E.H.
CHENNAI

As seasoned Tamil Nadu cricketers, N. Jagadeesan and Shahrukh Khan have weathered the full spectrum of the sport’s highs and lows.
Ahead of their Tuesday’s TNPL match, the Chepauk Super Gillies skipper and his Vida Kovai Kings counterpart gave elaborate and veracious answers to the challenges in their roles and careers.

‘One-ball game’
Commenting on his role as a finisher, Shahrukh said: “I am 31 now. And as a batter, when I was in my mid-20s, it [reflecting on his innings] felt completely different. But that’s the sport. No matter how set you are, it’s just a one-ball game... some days it comes off, and some days it doesn’t.”
Shahrukh touched upon the accolades and criticisms that come with being a middle-order batter.
“The toughest job is to play down the order. On days you do well, you are applauded more than anybody else. But on days when you don’t do well, you are put down more than anyone.”
On how he handles failures, Shahrukh added: “As a finisher, I need to

The moment I’m not able to accept failure, it becomes very difficult to express myself.
JAGADEESAN
have a good relationship with myself. Because no matter what, the most important thing is how you feel about yourself.”
Different approaches
Jagadeesan gave his perspective on life as a cricketer, and more specifically the nuances in shifting approaches in different formats.
“To put that in simple terms, I am okay to accept failure. The moment I’m not able to accept failure, it becomes very difficult to express myself. In this format, there could be a lot of failures, and that’s one thing that I’ve [told myself],” he said.

Love for the sport
“The relationship with failure comes from the love for the game. I started playing because I love the sport... and as you go on this professional journey, you stop enjoying the sport as it is, thinking about your selections and whatnot. In the end, it is just about you having faith in yourself.”

Shameemudheen emerges as the biggest buy in PVL auction

Sports Bureau

Kochi Blue Spikers secured Shameemudheen for ₹20 lakh at the Prime Volleyball League (PVL) season 5 auction at Anjuna, North Goa, on Monday, making the blocker the costliest player sold.
While defending champion Bengaluru Torpedoes made no moves, choosing to retain its entire championship-winning squad, Ahmedabad Defenders made five acquisitions, with C.K. Muhammad Nihal (₹19 lakh) on top of its list.
Calicut Heroes roped in eight players with Sameer Chaudhary (₹10 lakh), Suraj Chaudhary (₹9.5 lakh), Jaskaran Singh (₹9 lakh)

and Sarthak Singh Jadon (₹7.75 lakh) among them.
Shon T. John (₹15.5 lakh), Kunal Das (₹6.25 lakh) and Mohammed Zamrud (₹4 lakh) were roped in by Chennai Blitz, with Delhi Toofans adding Amrinderpal Singh (₹10 lakh), Vikas Maan (₹8 lakh), Ashok Vicky Gujar and M.V. Lal Sujan (₹3 lakh each).
Goa Guardians made two acquisitions while Blue Spikers also brought in R. Angamuthu (₹9.5 lakh). Telugu Blackhawks, previously known as Hyderabad Black Hawks, strengthened its squad with Tanish Choudhary (₹14 lakh) and Vinit Kumar (₹8 lakh). Kolkata Thunderbolts secured six players.

Prokofiev dazzles in Nizam’s Gold Cup

HYDERABAD: Trainer Prasanna Kumar’s ward Prokofiev, ridden by Antony Raj S, sprang an upset by winning the Nizam’s Gold Cup (Gr. 2), the feature event of Monday’s (Aug. 17) races, in a record time of 2m 3.41s.
The winner is owned by Mr. Zavaray S. Poonawalla, Mrs. Behroze Z. Poonawalla, Mr. Yohan Z. Poonawalla, Mrs. Michelle Y. Poonawalla, Ms. Delna Z. Poonawalla, Mrs. Simone Poonawalla Pandole & Mr. Rishad N. Pandole rep. Poonawalla Racing & Breeding Pvt. Ltd.
1. HIMAYAT SAGAR TROPHY (DIV. I, 1,100M): FLYING FURY (G. Nareesh) 1, Ek (Afroz K) 2, Her Ladyship (Mukesh K) 3 and Inderhasnush (A.A. Vikrant) 4. 3-1/2, 3 and 2-1/4. Im, 6.90s. ₹16 (w), 10, 13 and 24 (p). SHP: 27, THP: 76, FP: 29, Q: 19, Tanala: 198. Favourite: Flying Fury. Owner: Mr. Hussein Sultanali Nensey. Trainer: Robin R. Kondakalla.
2. DONCASTER PLATE (1,200M): LOVE IN PARIS (R.S. Jodha) 1, Queen Eternal (Ashad Asbar) 2, Classy Touch (Neeraj) 3 and Gacchanmanasvin (M.S. Deora) 4. 2, 2 and 2 (p). SHP: 39, THP: 71, FP: 58, Q: 24, Tanala: 316. Favourite: Queen Eternal. Owners: Mr. M. Raghunath rep. Gava Racing Syndicate LLP & Mr. P. Amarendra Reddy. Trainer: K. Satheesh.
3. B. MARIDESHWARA RAO MEMORIAL TROPHY (DIV. II)

(1,200M): GLORIA (Akshay Kumar) 1, Fortis (Trevor) 2, Dubai Touch (Trevor) 3 and Federer (P. Ajeeth K) 4. 3-1/2, 1-1/4 and 4. Im, 14.26s. ₹52 (w), 15, 10 and 13 (p). SHP: 47, THP: 30, FP: 190, Q: 32, Tanala: 731. Favourite: Fortis. Owners: Mr. Aditya P. Thackersey & Col. S.B. Nair. Trainer: L.V.R. Deshmukh.
4. HIMAYAT SAGAR TROPHY (DIV. I) (1,100M): OJAS MAXIMUS (A.A. Vikrant) 1, Linda (Akshay K) 2, Bold Beauty (Santosh Raj) 3 and Swiss Girl (Abhay Singh) 4. 5-3/4, Head and 2-3/4. Im, 7.82s. ₹13 (w), 10, 13 and 118 (p). SHP: 38, THP: 192, FP: 57, Q: 54, Tanala: 898. Favourite: Ojas Maximus. Owner: Mr. Vijay Anand Jangiti. Trainer: S. Sreekanth.
5. B. MARIDESHWARA RAO MEMORIAL TROPHY (DIV. I) (1,200M): EMERALD TOUCH (Neeraj Rawal) 1, Warwick (P. Ajeeth K) 2, Foxy Girl (Kuldeep Jr.) 3 and Strauss (D.S. Deora) 4. Head, 1-1/4 and 5-3/4. Im, 13. 81s. ₹16 (w), 10, 21 and 12 (p). SHP: 53, THP: 27, FP: 88, Q: 79, Tanala: 310. Favourite: Emerald Touch. Owner: Mr. N. Shyam Sunder. Trainer: Neelesh Rawal. **NOTE:** Zuza (Akshay K) up planted into the stalls and did not participate.
6. NIZAM’S GOLD CUP (GR.2) (2,000M): PROKOPIEV (Antony Raj S) 1, Vyasa (Ashad Asbar) 2, Red Bishop (Vivek G) 3 and Alfonsine (Trevor) 4. 3/4, 1/2 and Neck. 2m, 3.41s. (record time), ₹94 (w), 22, 18 and 14 (p). SHP: 103, THP: 36, FP: 1,975, Q: 1,214, Tanala: 17, 227. Favourite: Mayne Magic. Owners: Mr. Zavaray S. Poonawalla, Mrs. Behroze Z. Poonawalla, Mr. Yohan Z. Poonawalla, Mrs. Michelle Y. Poonawalla, Ms. Delna Z. Poonawalla, Mrs. Simone Poonawalla Pandole & Mr. Rishad N. Pandole rep. Poonawalla Racing & Breeding Pvt. Ltd. Trainer: Prasanna Kumar.
7. ROYAL WINDSOR PLATE (1,400M): ASHOKA (Akshay Kumar) 1, Black Onyx (D.S. Deora) 2, Lux Aeterna (Trevor) 3 and Brilliant Lad (Neeraj) 4. 2, 1/2 and 1/2. Im, 25.78s. ₹20 (w), 15, 22 and 10 (p). SHP: 55, THP: 42, FP: 123, Q: 96, Tanala: 312. Favourite: Ashoka. Owners: M/s. Prabhakar Chowdary Tripuraneni, Rama Sesu Eyyunni, Donald Anthony Netto & Tripuranenivenkata Aditya Chowdary. Trainer: D. Netto.
8. BROWN JACK PLATE (1,400M): RANI RUCKUS (G. Nareesh) 1, Hoping High (Mohit) 2, Aos Si (Antony Raj) 3 and Fortune Art (Kuldeep Sr.) 4. 4, 1.2 and 8-1/4. Im, 28. 98s. ₹52 (w), 16, 15 and 13 (p). SHP: 34, THP: 49, FP: 195, Q: 85, Tanala: 431. Favourite: Aos Si. Owner: Mr. Rakesh Reddy Kondakalla. Trainer: Robin R. Kondakalla.
Jackpot: 70%: ₹7,828 (58 tkts.) & 30%: 325 (598 tkts.).
Mini Jackpot: (i) 2,975 (24 tkts.), (ii) 5,154 (14 tkts.).
Trebble: (i) 1,300 (20 tkts.), 805 (30 tkts.), (iii) 1,703 (21 tkts.).

R. Kaushik
GALLE

As scrambled single to mid-off, a little leap in the air. The helmet whipped off, arms held half aloft, his face bathed in a million-dollar smile. And just like that, Devdutt Padikkal became the 84th player to conjure a Test century for India.

And it wasn't just any hundred. It was Padikkal's maiden three-figure knock in the five-day game, in only his third Test appearance. These three appearances have come over a period of 29 months, which isn't a reflection on the left-hander's abilities but more a pointer to the logjam for places in the Indian batting which, despite its recent spin-infested afflictions at home, is still a formidable force.

Each of the 26-year-old's caps has come because someone else has been unavailable. His debut, against England in March 2024, was a proverbial last-minute development, after Rajat Patidar was ruled out with an injury to his left ankle on the morning of the match. Summoned at little notice, Padikkal hardly looked out of place at No. 4, stroking his way to a majestic 65 marked by handsome strokes through the off-side off the back foot on a surface that encouraged that style of play.

Eight and a half months later, as India lined up for the first of five Tests against Australia at the sprawling Optus Stadium in Perth, out went the SOS to the Karnataka batter, this time because Shubman Gill was unavailable after fracturing his left thumb while fielding in the slips in an intra-squad simulation match. Despite having had greater time to come to terms with his overseas debut, Padikkal found little joy in the Western Australia capital in the first innings, nicked off by Josh Hazlewood for a 23-ball duck. He batted with a little more composure in the second innings as he came in on the back of a 201-run opening stand between Yashasvi Jaiswal and K.L. Rahul, but couldn't progress beyond 25 as he was dismissed for the second time in the Test by Hazlewood.

Since then, it has been a whirlwind ride for the rangy left-hander, majestic and authoritative with an all-round game that he has used as an ally in domestic and franchise cricket. He had a fantastic time of it in IPL 2026 for defending champions Royal Challengers Bengaluru, fusing aggression with consistency in making 464 runs at a wonderful strike-rate of 168.72. Only Virat Kohli (675) and skipper Patidar (501) made more runs for the holders, and of those who made at least 250 runs, only Patidar (192.69) and Tim David (188.27) boasted a better rate of scoring. To say that Padikkal was one of the engine rooms as the Bengaluru franchise emulated Chennai Super Kings and Mumbai Indians by becoming only the third franchise to retain the IPL crown will be a gross understatement.

Leader of sorts

Within the RCB setup, Padikkal had grown into a leader of sorts. New skipper Patidar was clearly in charge, but Padikkal was no longer one of the happy-go-lucky boys. Given a high-profile role at No. 3 to take on the bowling from the get-go, Padikkal had grown into that responsibility; the fear of being dismissed was replaced by a quiet confidence in his assiduous preparation, and it was hardly a surprise to see him repeatedly deposit his first ball out of the park, with correctness and elegance and no more than a semblance of power.

That he was growing in stature had earlier been evidenced by Amit Verma's selection panel bestowing on him the captaincy of the Karnataka Ranji Trophy side midway through a stop-start campaign that was seemingly taking them nowhere. As they relieved Mayank Agarwal of the leadership role, the hat sat snugly on Padikkal's head; justifying the show of faith, the new captain reeled off several impactful knocks as he hauled his team to the title round, where the hosts came up short against an inspired Jammu & Kashmir in the final in Hubballi.

His exploits caught the eye of Gautam Gambhir, the Indian head coach, and chief selector Ajit Agarkar. India had rewarded Karun Nair's stellar domestic run by recalling him to the Test set-up after a long gap on the tour of England last summer, but Karun didn't exactly cash in, making just a solitary half-century in the final Test at the Oval to play himself out of contention. A disastrous set of matches against South Africa at home in November last meant India had to revisit their options going forward as their World Test Championship aspirations hung by a slender thread.

Padikkal was earmarked as a sure-shot Test option, though no one was quite sure when his turn would come. There was a slant towards Dhruv Jurel to occupy a middle-order position, so if Padikkal had to be accommodated, it would have to be in the top three. But the decision-makers had thrown their weight behind the performing opening duo of Rahul and Jaiswal and the perceived promise at No. 3 of Sai Sudharsan, so it seemed as if Padikkal's time wasn't nigh yet.

But as is often the case, one man's misfortune is another's opportunity. Sudharsan, not exactly translating backing and potential into consistent

Padikkal's first salvo — a win for planning and preparation

The 26-year-old hits his maiden Test century in just his third appearance in the longest format; with the southpaw finding chances hard to come by, the big knock against Sri Lanka is worth its weight in gold

Within the RCB setup, Padikkal had grown into a leader of sorts. Patidar was clearly in charge, but the top-order batter was no longer one of the happy-go-lucky boys. There was no surprise when he was handed the Karnataka captaincy

In the performance against Sri Lanka, the decisiveness in foot movement was the standout feature. The left-hander ended a 35-innings wait for an Indian No. 3 to keep his tryst with three-figures in Test cricket

performances, seemed to have nailed down the No. 3 berth after making centuries for India 'A' in consecutive unofficial 'Tests' in Sri Lanka in June and July, until a stress reaction in his big toe led to him being ruled out of the ongoing Test series. Arrive Padikkal, stage left. This time, as he took a bow after a virtuoso performance, there was a strong, lingering feeling that he wouldn't have to wait another 21 months for his next Test appearance.

Pivotal position

The No. 3 position is a massively responsible, pivotal one in Test cricket. India have been blessed with exceptional personnel who manned that spot for long periods; since the turn of the millennium, the two men who made No. 3 their very own were Rahul Dravid, Padikkal's Statemate and the former National captain, and Cheteshwar Pujara.

From the middle of 2023 until last summer, when he was named Rohit Sharma's successor as the Test captain, Gill was a prolific scorer after stepping into Pujara's shoes in the Caribbean. But once Gill dropped down to No. 4 – the spot opened up after Kohli's Test retirement – the quest for the No. 3 began afresh.

In the last few years, India have tried out numerous options in a desperate bid to unearth a dependable hand that can steer the ship through choppy waters. That quest has taken them through a fair few names – Sudharsan, the aforementioned Karun, Rahul himself and Washington Sundar – but the fact that no one had scored a Test century from No. 3 since Gill in September 2024 against Bangladesh in Chennai reiterated that they had yet to button down a one-for-the-future choice. Sudharsan emerged as the one that enjoyed the backing of the coach and the captain, but now, Padikkal has stolen a march and has the chance to build on the

gains of the Galle Test next week in the Sri Lankan capital.

Padikkal's first of what is certain to be several Test tons was a win for planning and preparation. Between the 'A' tour in which he scored 12, 67 and 94 and embarking for Sri Lanka again, Padikkal trained hard at the Karnataka Institute of Cricket with personal coach Naseeruddin Mohammed. It wasn't just mindless, 'let's get through the grind' training; a lot of thought had gone into what were the areas that needed to be addressed. Among them was getting a feel of playing consistently against the red Kookaburra ball, and getting used to different types of spinners – variety- and height-wise – on pitches offering varying degrees of turn in a concerted bid to replicate what was expected to be on offer during the Tests in Sri Lanka.

Batters often make minute, conditions-based technical adjustments that are so subtle that they often go unnoticed. In the IPL, for instance, Padikkal relied heavily on an upright stance. At KIOC, he worked hard to stay low so that he could get to the pitch of the ball to smother turn. Hard hands are a must in T20 cricket but an absolute no-no on turning tracks, so Padikkal embarked on another exciting journey to consciously keep the hands softer, to drop his wrists, so that he didn't put the close-in cordon in business.

Staking a claim

All this, even when he wasn't sure that he'd get a look-in. Ten days back in Colombo, with Sudharsan's tour banging in the balance, Padikkal staked his claim all over again with an unbeaten 142 against an SLC XI, and once the Tamil Nadu left-hander was officially ruled out, it was obvious that Padikkal's time to rise and shine was imminent.

What stood out when he took guard at

the Galle International Stadium on Saturday, day one of the first Test, was his self-belief. It must have helped that he walked out to join his senior Karnataka colleague, because Rahul and he share a terrific relationship with the older man taking his state captain under his wing, so to say. Padikkal started like he often did in the IPL, with a pulled four (off debutant off-spinner Keshara Nuwantha) off the first ball he faced. A couple of deliveries later, he put on his dancing shoes to shimmy down the track and deposit experienced left-arm spinner Prabath Jayasuriya over the long-on fence. Padikkal had bared his hand, but Sri Lanka had nothing to counter him with.

The day-one surface had plenty for the spinners, but Padikkal was unstoppable. Without hitting a stroke in anger, he moved through the gears effortlessly, overshadowing Rahul's calm, unflustered presence with a glittering array of delectable strokes. The decisiveness in foot movement was the most standout feature as he ended a 35-innings wait for an Indian No. 3 to keep his tryst with three-figures in Test cricket.

By the time he was finally dismissed after five and a half hours of the most compelling presence in the middle, Padikkal had eased – there really is no more appropriate word – to 167. In all the years that India have travelled to Sri Lanka, only Sachin Tendulkar (203), Virender Sehwag (201) and Shikhar Dhawan (190) have registered a numerically more substantial individual score. That Padikkal wasn't satisfied with just a tryst with three-figures but aimed bigger and higher must delight Gill and Gambhir no end.

Having fired the first salvo, it's entirely up to Padikkal to make himself undroppable. And thereby to make sure that he doesn't keep having to look over his shoulder.

THE GIST

▼ In the last few years, India have tried out numerous options in a desperate bid to unearth a dependable hand that can steer the ship through choppy waters. Padikkal has stolen a march and has the chance to build on the gains of the Galle Test in the Sri Lankan capital

▼ Padikkal trained hard at the Karnataka Institute of Cricket with personal coach Naseeruddin. In a concerted bid to succeed in Sri Lanka, he played consistently against the red Kookaburra ball, and got used to different types of spinners on pitches offering varying degrees of turn

▼ The day-one surface in Galle had plenty for the spinners, but Padikkal was unstoppable. Without hitting a stroke in anger, he moved through the gears effortlessly



AFP

Text & Context

THE HINDU

NEWS IN NUMBERS

Unemployment rate among persons aged 15 years and above

5.1 in per cent. Overall unemployment rate among persons aged 15 years and above declined to 5.1% in July 2026 from 5.5% in the previous month, according to a survey. The Unemployment Rate (UR) was 4.5% in rural areas. The urban UR remained almost steady at 6.7% in July. PTI

Persons killed by Ebola outbreak in DR Congo in 3 months

2,300 A fast-spreading Ebola outbreak in the Democratic Republic of Congo is now the country's deadliest ever after killing more than 2,300 people in three months, government figures showed on Monday. AFP

Number of MPs who have criminal cases against them

326 A report on criminalisation of politics submitted in the Supreme Court has stated that 251 members out of 543 in the Lok Sabha and 75 lawmakers out of 233 in the Rajya Sabha have criminal cases against them. PTI

Foreign nationals to be deported by Pakistan for cybercrimes

284 Pakistan will deport 284 foreign nationals for alleged involvement in sextortion and other cybercrimes, an official said on Monday. Most of them arrived in Pakistan on tourist visas and were operating from a registered IT business in Islamabad, the official said. PTI

Staff removed as NTA undertakes exam system overhaul

50 The National Testing Agency (NTA) has removed more than 50 of its staff members and is onboarding professionals for key leadership positions as part of measures to reform the overall examination system, the Education Ministry said on Monday. PTI
COMPILED BY THE HINDU DATA TEAM

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The road to E20 is not without bumps

India's rapid transition to E20 fuel has raised concerns over mileage loss, mechanical wear, contamination risks and the lack of an unblended petrol option for millions of legacy vehicles; the debate underlines the need for clearer fuel labelling, quality controls and independent real-world studies

FULL CONTEXT

O.R.S. Rao

India's rapid transition to a nationwide E20 fuel regime (petrol blended with 20% anhydrous ethanol) has triggered a complex multidimensional debate at the intersection of macroeconomic energy policy, automotive engineering, supply-chain quality control, and consumer protection. While championed by the Government of India to reduce crude oil import dependency, save foreign exchange, and reduce carbon emissions, the rollout has ignited widespread friction regarding real-world mileage drops, mechanical vulnerabilities in legacy vehicles, chemical contamination risks, and the elimination of unblended petrol (EO) as a user choice at retail pumps.

The regulatory baseline

The Government of India notified on February 17, 2026, that, effective April 1, 2026, all States and Union Territories must sell petrol blended with up to 20% ethanol and a minimum Research Octane Number (RON) of 95. It replaces the earlier 2021 notification that permitted blending of up to 10% ethanol.

Earlier, the government mandated that all automobile manufacturers comply with the Bharat Stage 6 Phase 2 Real Driving Emissions (BS 6 Phase 2 RDE) norms starting in April 2023.

Vehicles manufactured to comply with Real Driving Emissions (RDE) norms were factory-engineered with ethanol-resistant fluorinated rubber (FKM/Viton), upgraded fuel pump seals, and recalibrated Powertrain Control Modules (PCMs).

The legacy fleet, built before April 2023, was factory-calibrated for E5 or E10 configurations, featuring traditional Nitrile Butadiene Rubber (NBR) and metallic fuel system components lacking chemical shielding against higher alcohol concentrations.

Consumer surveys highlight widespread friction: over 66% of pre-2023 vehicle owners report mileage loss exceeding 10%, and 55% cite higher maintenance frequency and component wear-out.

In a written reply in Rajya Sabha, the Minister of State for Petroleum and Natural Gas, Suresh Gopi, informed the House that the Ministry of Heavy Industries had not conducted any formal assessment to determine the share of India's vehicle fleet that is genuinely E20-compatible. India's active petrol-powered vehicle pool is estimated at roughly 310 million units and may be classified broadly as shown in **Table 1**, based on surveys and social media.

While about 70 million post-April 2023 vehicles possess certified factory-level E20 compatibility, the remaining 240 million legacy vehicles, most of which are two-wheelers, rely on fuel delivery sub-assemblies built for E5 or E10 parameters.

Engineering realities

Ethanol functions as a powerful polar solvent and natural detergent. In older legacy vehicles, steel fuel tanks inevitably develop microscopic oxidised scale, rust layers, and varnish residues from years of standard petrol usage. When E20 is introduced, the alcohol scours and dislodges these dormant rust particles, suspending them in the fuel stream. This suspended particulate sludge quickly clogs inline fuel filters, chokes fuel pump strainers, and abrades high-pressure fuel

A fleet in transition

Around 70 million newer vehicles are E-20-compatible, while 240 million legacy vehicles were built for lower ethanol blends

Vehicle category	BS 6 Phase 2 compliant (post-April 2023)	Non-compliant / legacy (pre-April 2023)	Total estimated fleet (approx)
Two-Wheelers (Motorcycles & scooters)	55 million to 60 million	200 million to 210 million	260 million
Four-Wheelers (Passenger cars & SUVs)	12 million to 15 million	35 million to 38 million	50 million
Combined fleet (approx.)	70 million	240 million	310 million
Combined fleet % share	23%	77%	100%



GETTY IMAGES

injector nozzles, causing erratic spray patterns and engine misfires.

Being strongly hygroscopic, Ethanol draws ambient moisture directly from the air. In humid environments or during prolonged parking, the absorbed water reaches its saturation point, causing the ethanol-water mixture to separate from the gasoline (phase separation) and settle at the bottom of the fuel tank. This stagnant, acidic water-alcohol layer directly attacks the bare metal base of legacy steel tanks, accelerating severe internal pitting and bottom-tank perforation.

In pre-2023 fuel circuits, conventional NBR rubber hoses, O-rings, and pump diaphragms absorb ethanol, leading to swelling, premature hardening, embrittlement, and fuel leaks.

Because ethanol contains roughly 30-35% less energy per unit volume than petrol, unadjusted ignition timing in older engines results in reduced thermal efficiency, mileage penalties, and localised carbon/soot accumulation on spark plugs and valves.

Major vulnerabilities

The physical risks of ethanol blending are not limited to vehicle fuel tanks; they represent a major operational challenge at the retail dealer storage level.

Most retail petrol pumps in India utilise Underground Steel Tanks (UST). During heavy monsoons, waterlogging, or due to aged manhole gaskets, surface run-off can seep into UST vent pipes and inspection pits. While pure petrol floats on top of water with minimal mixing (allowing water to be pumped out from the bottom), E20 absorbs water instantaneously. When moisture ingress in a dealer's UST exceeds the critical saturation threshold (typically around 0.5% water content), catastrophic phase separation occurs within thousands of litres of fuel. The separated, low-octane, highly corrosive water-ethanol layer is drawn by the submerged suction pumps directly into the dispensing nozzles, leading to catastrophic engine stalling and immediate fuel system failure in customer vehicles.

Beyond retail seepage, fuel quality is vulnerable to chemical contaminants introduced during distillation,

dehydration, and transit.

Originating from agrochemical residues in sugarcane/grain feedstocks or chemical reagents used during distillery processing, trace chlorides form hydrochloric acid during combustion, causing severe corrosion in high-pressure fuel injectors and cylinder walls.

If dehydration units (molecular sieves) falter at distilleries, or transport tankers fail to maintain hermetic seals, excessive water content enters the supply chain prior to retail delivery.

Scientific divergence

The controversy deepened following a report from the Engine Research Laboratory at IIT Kanpur, asserting that E20 fuel causes no notable engine damage and that efficiency drops are restricted to under 5%. The institute attributed minor mileage fluctuations primarily to driving behaviours, localized traffic congestion, and variable ambient conditions rather than fuel chemistry alone.

However, these institutional findings have met with profound scepticism from independent automotive experts and consumer communities. Forums like r/CarsIndia have actively documented structural discrepancies, noting that labelling legacy, E10-calibrated engines entirely safe for E20 overlooks material science limitations. Reports highlight that auxiliary peripheral systems experience catastrophic wear even if engine blocks remain intact. Real-world logs from independent mechanics highlight premature fuel pump and injector failures, which they attribute to ethanol's low lubricity and aggressive solvent properties.

Adding significant weight to the technical debate are the leaked internal industry communications reviewed by Reuters and subsequent industry clarifications. The data reviewed by Reuters revealed that top automakers harboured deep private anxieties regarding chemical contaminants in E20 fuel, referencing tests of over 250 fuel samples across 21 States.

While official standards specify a maximum ceiling of 3 ppm, industry samples logged readings from 6 to 570 ppm in Rajasthan, 1.4 to 420 ppm in

Delhi, and 10 to 357 ppm in Maharashtra. Automakers noted modern high-pressure injectors have a tolerance threshold near 1 ppm. Water content was found to reach up to 12,500 ppm in Uttar Pradesh and 13,000 ppm in Andhra Pradesh (against standard operating thresholds). Internal emails warned that organic chlorides could ruin engine components "within 200 km".

Following the leak, the Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers (SIAM) issued detailed media clarifications on August 4 and August 13. SIAM clarified that the withdrawn document contained preliminary data collected by very few OEMs intended solely for internal discussion, which had not been authenticated or reviewed by the broader membership. SIAM announced plans to conduct a comprehensive, validated scientific study, in collaboration with members and technical experts to guide future policy submissions.

The Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas confirmed that State-run fuel networks adhere to stringent testing, treating contamination reports as localised anomalies.

Need for balancing

To bridge the gap between national macro-economic ambitions and ground-level realities, a pragmatic, multi-pronged corrective framework is required.

Fuel retail outlets must be mandated to maintain dual-dispensing infrastructure, reintroducing lower-blend or unblended fuel (EO/E10) as a "protection-grade" option. This restores informed consumer choice under the Consumer Protection Act for owners of legacy two-wheelers and older passenger cars.

Clear, standardised visual labelling must be enforced at every retail fuel dispenser indicating ethanol content. Furthermore, oil marketing companies (OMCs) should publish regular batch-level quality metrics regarding moisture and chloride limits to prevent infrastructure-led contamination.

Regulatory bodies should incentivise the development and certification of affordable, aftermarket retrofit kits (such as ethanol-resistant fuel lines and reinforced seals) for legacy vehicles. Simultaneously, structured service guidelines should be issued to help vehicle owners mitigate the risks of phase separation and corrosion.

Moving beyond controlled laboratory trials, an independent, transparent, and multi-year empirical study tracking real-world pre-2023 fleet performance across diverse geographic and climatic conditions must be commissioned to permanently settle the scientific debate.

Brazil, one of the global leaders in biofuels, also faced similar bumps, but they steered clear of them successfully using shock absorbers. India can learn from their biofuel journey.

The way forward

The E20 mandate requires a consumer-centric pivot. To protect the interests of consumers who own over 240 million legacy vehicles, the government may introduce dual-fuel dispensing, ensuring unblended petrol accessibility as a user choice at petrol outlets. Beyond laboratory trials, independent field audits, clear pump labelling, and subsidised retrofit support, particularly for two-wheelers, are essential. Balancing macroeconomic energy goals with consumer protection measures is critical to regaining public trust.

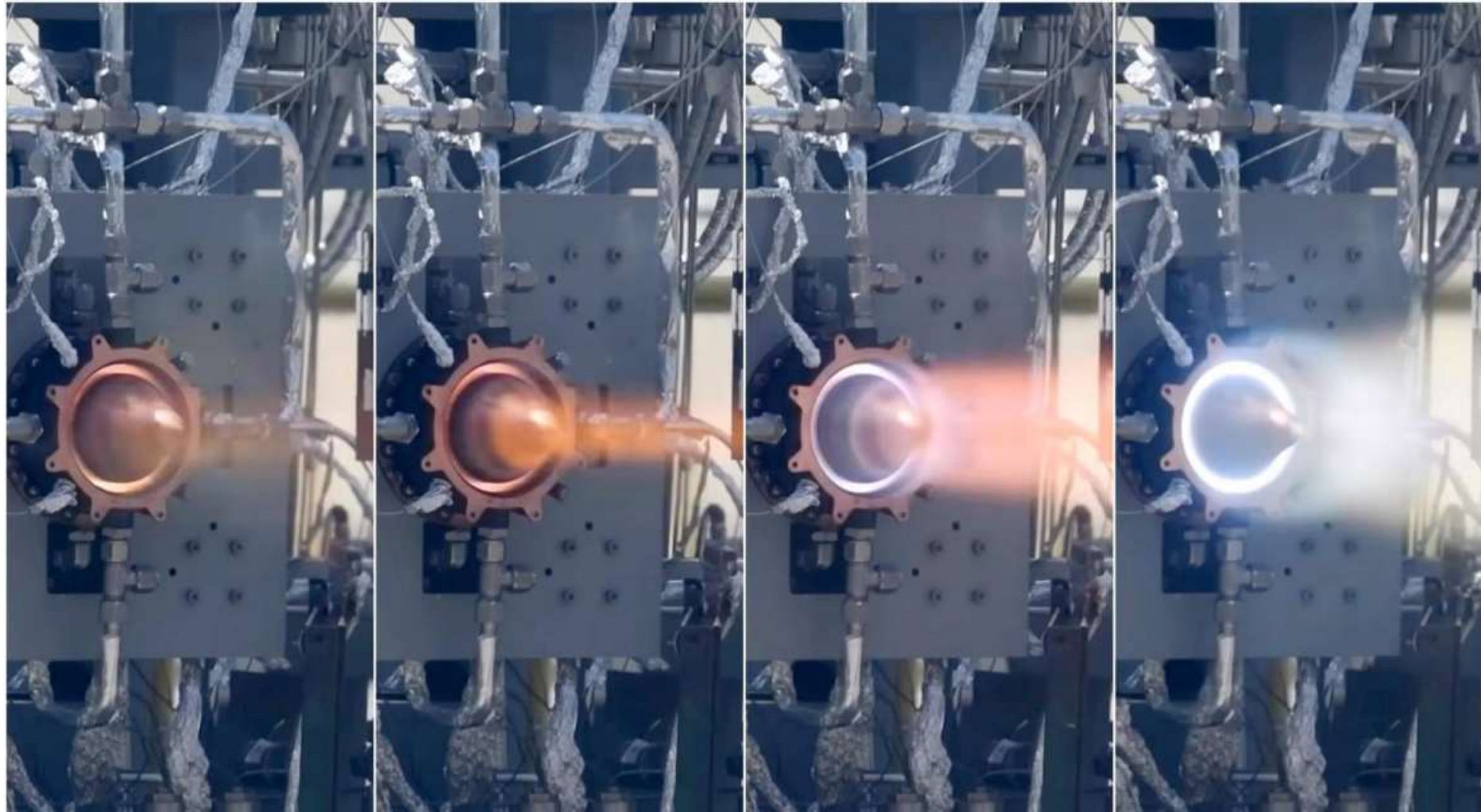
(Prof. O R S Rao is the Chancellor of the ICAI University, Sikkim. Views are personal)

THE GIST

India's petrol fleet is divided between newer E20-compatible vehicles and a much larger legacy fleet built for E5 or E10.

Ethanol's solvent and water-absorbing properties can affect older fuel systems, including tanks, hoses, pumps and injectors.

While IIT Kanpur reports limited efficiency losses and no notable engine damage, industry data and consumer reports point to concerns over fuel contamination and component failures.



A full-scale rotating detonation engine comes on during a NASA test in 2023. During the test, it fired for 251 seconds, a record at the time. NASA

Rotating detonation engines: the science and the promises

Vasudevan Mukunth

Recently, India-based defence start-up D-Porpulse announced that it had successfully demonstrated a rotating detonation engine at a Defence Research & Development Organisation facility in Hyderabad.

A rotating detonation engine, or RDE, is an engine design that promises to use fuel more efficiently than conventional rocket engines. Launching satellites to space on rockets and carrying explosives to distant targets on missiles are both expensive. If an engine can use fuel more efficiently, it will need correspondingly less fuel to achieve the same task. This saving can be passed to the payload, whether a satellite or a warhead, increasing the profitability of the mission. At least on paper.

In January, GE Aerospace and Lockheed Martin demonstrated an RDE for hypersonic missiles (using air from the atmosphere). In February, U.S.-based SpaceWorks reported hot-fire tests of its RDE for rockets. Its compatriots Astrobotic test-fired its Chakram RDE continuously for 300 seconds and L3Harris announced that it had tested two RDEs, in April and May respectively.

The Swiss start-up Stellar Alpina completed a commercial RDE hot-fire test and raised CHF 3.5 million while Juno Propulsion raised \$1.4 million to develop an RDE for spacecraft thrusters. In July, Venus Aerospace (then partnered with Lockheed Martin) raised \$91 million to scale its tested RDE.

Wait for advances

RDEs are currently confined to research and development. There are no models

known to be ready for commercial or military use.

The actual data from many tests by commercial entities are also not available in the public domain. But going by their physics alone, RDEs offer around 10% to 25% more thermodynamic efficiency than conventional combustors. The exact value depends on real-world conditions and the engine's design.

This is considered to be significant for rocket launches. Thermodynamic efficiency measures how much chemical energy becomes useful work. If an RDE improves thermodynamic efficiency by 20%, for instance, it could theoretically require around 17% less fuel for the same output, assuming other losses are unchanged.

Scientists figured out how an RDE could work by the 1960s. Building one was a different matter. Sustaining a continuous detonation in a compact chamber requires engineers to precisely control the injection of the fuel and the internal pressure.

The chamber also needs to have a specific geometry to ensure the engine works as desired.

Unlike in regular engines, even small instabilities in the fuel-air mixture in an RDE can destabilise the engine.

The engine materials must also withstand more than 2,000°C, 10-100 atmospheres of pressure (and in brief moments much higher), detonation speeds of more than 1,500 m/s, pressures oscillating at several thousand cycles per second, and potentially tens to hundreds of g, depending on the design.

So to invent working RDEs, scientists and engineers had to wait for advances in high-speed computing, diagnostics, fuel injection, materials, and manufacturing.

Supersonic flame

In a regular engine, the combustion chamber holds the fuel-air mixture. When a flame is introduced in the chamber – like from a spark plug – it travels through the mixture at less than the speed of sound. This is called a deflagration.

When the flame travels through the mixture at more than the speed of sound, it imposes a shock wave on the mixture and heats it up, triggering rapid combustion behind it. This is called a detonation. It is also what happens in the combustion chamber of a detonation engine.

As the flame passes through the mixture in a regular engine, the combustion happens at constant pressure. This means the mixture is free to expand as it heats up instead of being confined under pressure.

But when the flame passes through the mixture as a detonation, the combustion happens at constant volume. This is because the detonation compresses the unburned mixture with a shock wave immediately before combustion, and the mixture doesn't have enough time to expand under these 'forces'.

This is also why a detonation engine produces combustion products at a higher pressure, and more of the fuel's chemical energy is converted into pressure rather than being shed as heat. This is essentially the physics of how a detonation engine can have more fuel efficiency than a 'regular' engine with the same fuel.

Pulsed and rotating detonation

A simple type of the detonation engine is called the pulsed detonation engine, or PDE. A PDE has a long tube as the combustion chamber, to allow the

detonation to pass through the whole mixture.

First, the detonation races down the tube, rapidly compressing and burning the fuel-air mixture. This leaves behind a very hot, high-pressure combustion products. Those gases expand towards the open end of the tube, where they exit at a high speed.

By Newton's third law, their momentum in one direction produces an equal and opposite momentum on the engine, pushing it forward. Alternatively, if the engine is connected to a piston, the same expanding gases would push on it, generating mechanical energy. The tube is then purged before the next cycle begins.

An RDE makes the detonation a continuous process. Instead of the detonation passing through a long tube, it is made to flow in a circle. In the general RRDE design, the combustion chamber has an annular shape, i.e. two concentric cylinders with a narrow ring-shaped gap between them. The fuel and the oxidiser are injected continuously into this gap, called the annulus, even as one or more detonation waves race through.

As the detonation goes round and round, it continuously imposes high pressures and temperatures on the mixture.

And to keep the detonation going, fuel is continuously injected into the annulus just ahead of the detonation wave. The wave consumes the fresh fuel-air mixture and expels the products through the nozzle, along its axis. So as long as the fuel keeps coming at the right time and in the right conditions, the detonation can keep going – even at thousands of times per second.

This is how an RDE can continuously generate thrust (or mechanical energy).

THE DAILY QUIZ

India crossed the 600-Test mark on August 15 when it took to the field for the first Test against Sri Lanka in Galle. Here is a quiz on India's cricketing journey

Nazir Ahamed A.S.

QUESTION 1

QUESTION 2
India crossed the 300th and 500th Test milestones at Home. When and where did India play these matches?

QUESTION 3
India is the third nation to achieve the feat of 600 Test matches. Which are the other two?

QUESTION 4
What is India's rank in overall Test wins?

QUESTION 5
How many years did India take to cross its 100-Test mark?

QUESTION 6

When did Indian women make their Test debut?



Visual Question:
Who is this Indian batter celebrating his maiden Test century in Galle? PTI

Questions and Answers to the previous day's daily quiz: 1.

Indonesia is recognised as the largest of this type of political entity because of more than 17,000 islands spread between the Indian and Pacific oceans under its control. What type of state?

Ans: Archipelagic state

2. Name the legendary first president of Indonesia from 1945 to 1967 and his daughter. **Ans: Sukarno and Megawati Sukarnoputri**

3. Name the invisible biogeographical boundary that separates Asian and Australian wildlife zones within the archipelago. **Ans: Wallace Line**

4. Name the Indonesian textile art using wax that was given a UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage status in 2009. **Ans: Batik**

5. What is Indonesia's National emblem, which gets its name from a mythical

bird from Indian mythology? **Ans: ‘Garuda Pancasila’**

6. Indonesia is relocating its capital away from Jakarta to a purpose-built city in Borneo. What is it called? **Ans: Nusantara**

7. Indonesia is home to the world’s largest Buddhist temple, built in the 9th-century in Central Java, that has nine stacked platforms and thousands of relief panels. Name this UNESCO World Heritage Site. **Ans: Borobudur**

8. Name the real-life couple who gave Indonesia’s first-ever Olympic gold medals in 1992 and in which sport? **Ans: Susi Susanti and Alan Budikusuma in badminton**

Visual: A large lizard, considered the largest extant lizard, which gets its name from an Indonesian island to which it is endemic. **Ans: Komodo Dragon**

Early Birds: Prem Nath Tiwari | C. Saravanan | Anand Biswas | Siddhartha Viswanathan | Tito Shiladitva



FROM THE ARCHIVES

Know your English

S. Upendran

What is the meaning and origin of the expression “Can’t hold a candle to someone?” (T.D.V. Raman, Chennai)

When you say that someone cannot hold a candle to you, what you are implying is that the other person is not equal to you; he/she is in fact inferior to you. The expression can be used with things as well. Here are a few examples.

As a teacher, Satish can’t hold a candle to Atul.

According to Manaswini, no pop group can hold a candle to the Beatles.

This is one of those expressions that has been around for several hundred years. Before the days of electricity, it was common practice to light candles after the sun went down. Since street lighting was almost non-existent, the fairly well to do had servants who followed them everywhere carrying a candle. It was also possible to hire “linkboys”. These boys carried with them lanterns and candles and they provided the necessary light for the people going from one part of the town to another. Since the servants and the linkboys were looked down upon by the masters, the expression “can’t hold a candle to someone” began to mean someone who is inferior.

What is the difference between “partially cooked” and “partly cooked”? (T. Sundaram, Vellore)

There is a tendency to use the words “partially” and “partly” interchangeably. But careful users of the language make a distinction between the two. When you say that the rice has been partially cooked, it implies that it has not been completely cooked. In other words, it has been underdone; it needs to be boiled some more. On the other hand, when you say that it has been “partly” cooked, it seems to suggest that while certain portions have been cooked properly, some others have not been properly cooked. Perhaps some parts have been partially cooked! It is possible for a person to eat rice that has been partly cooked; he can eat the portion that has been cooked properly. You can also eat rice that has been partially cooked, but you may end up with a stomach-ache.

How do you pronounce ‘schizophrenia’? (Swarup Dey Sarkar, Bokaro)

The word consists of four syllables. The first syllable is pronounced like the word “skit”, while the second is pronounced like the word “so”. The third syllable sounds like the word “free”; while the final “ia” is like the “ear” in “near”, “dear”, and “fear”. The main stress is on the third syllable “phre”. Some people pronounce the “o” in the second syllable like the “a” in “China”.

Any idea what the word means?

Schizophrenia is a mental disorder; people who withdraw into a totally different world, one that has nothing to do with reality, are said to be suffering from schizophrenia. In informal speech, the word is often reduced to “schizo”, although this may not be the polite thing to do when talking seriously about someone with a mental disorder.

Published in The Hindu on August 21, 2001

Word of the day

Vagary:
an unexpected and inexplicable change in something

Synonyms: whimsy, unpredictability, impulse

Usage: *His vagaries often confuse his friends.*

Pronunciation: newsth.live/vagary

International Phonetic Alphabet: /veɪgəri/

For feedback and suggestions for Text & Context, please write to **letters@thehindu.co.in** with the subject 'Text & Context'